Police–Civilian Fatal Encounters and State Trust*

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Abstract

We study how high-profile police–civilian fatal encounters shape trust in the state. Combining survey responses from seventeen Latin American countries over twenty-five years with a new event dataset, we exploit event timing relative to survey interviews. Civilian-death events reduce institutional trust, whereas police-officer-death events increase it, with no detectable effects on interpersonal trust. Trust responses are concentrated among civilian-death events receiving timely national media coverage. Unrelated domestic disasters delay reporting of both event types, consistent with competition for limited media attention and an information-transmission mechanism.

Keywords. state, police, trust, Latin America.

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1 Introduction

Trust in state institutions is central to the relationship between citizens and government. It shapes support for public policy and citizens' willingness to rely on public institutions (e.g., Kuziemko et al. 2015), and ultimately bears on the effectiveness of the state. Institutional trust is also responsive to citizens' experiences with government performance (Besley et al., 2026). Yet it can be particularly fragile when the state exercises coercive force (Ang et al., 2025). Public debate over police violence has intensified worldwide, often following highly visible fatal encounters. Such events can become focal points not only for concerns about policing, but also for mass political mobilization and broader racial and partisan divisions over the legitimacy of state authority (Reny and Newman, 2021; Ang and Tebes, 2024).[1] We study how such violent interactions between police and civilians causally affect citizens' trust in the state and how the public information environment shapes that response.

A simple conceptual distinction guides our analysis, but the effect of police-civilian fatal encounters on institutional trust is a priori ambiguous. Citizens may value both the state's restraint in exercising coercive power and its capacity to provide public order. A civilian-death event—in which police officers kill one or more civilians—may reduce trust if citizens interpret it as evidence of abuse, incompetence, or weak accountability. But the same type of event may increase trust if the civilians involved are perceived as dangerous offenders or criminals and the use of force is viewed as effective law enforcement. Similarly, a police-officer-death event—in which civilians kill one or more police officers—may increase trust by heightening concern about insecurity and the demand for effective state protection, but it may also reduce trust if it is interpreted as evidence that the state is unable to maintain public order (Atkinson and Stiglitz, 2015). The net effect is therefore an empirical question. In either case, however, these responses require that citizens learn about the event, which motivates our focus on the information environment and the timing of media coverage.

We combine twenty-five years of nationally representative surveys from the Latin American Public Opinion Project (LAPOP) and Latinobarómetro with a new dataset of high-profile police-civilian fatal encounters across seventeen Latin American countries. The harmonized surveys provide comparable measures of institutional trust and exact interview dates. We construct the event dataset through systematic manual searches of major national news outlets and verify each case by reading the underlying articles. This process identifies

[1] Recent examples include the deaths of George Floyd in the United States (2020) and Nahel Merzouk in France (2023), both of which generated widespread public debate and protest (e.g., *New York Times*; *Le Monde*). In Latin America, the killings of Javier Ordóñez in Colombia (2020) and João Pedro Matos Pinto in Brazil (2020) similarly received extensive national coverage (e.g., *El Tiempo*; *Folha de S. Paulo*).

196 civilian-death events and 1,070 police-officer-death events between 2000 and 2024. We also collect the publication dates and semantic characteristics of the articles documenting each event, allowing us to study both the occurrence of the events and how information about them enters the national media environment.

Identifying the causal effect of fatal encounters is challenging because violence and attitudes toward the state may respond to the same economic and political conditions. To overcome this challenge, we exploit the timing of events relative to ongoing (and previously scheduled) survey fieldwork. Surveys are implemented over several weeks, and thus an event occurring during fieldwork divides respondents into those interviewed immediately before and immediately after it. Our research design compares these respondents within the same country and survey and within a narrow $\pm$12-day window around the event. Simulating reallocation of event dates within countries shows that the observed overlap between events and survey fieldwork is consistent with random timing, respondent characteristics are balanced around the events, and multiple evidence suggests that survey fieldwork is not disrupted by the events under study. This design follows a growing literature exploiting the timing of unexpected events relative to survey interviews (e.g., Depetris-Chauvin et al. 2020).

We find a clear asymmetry in how citizens respond to the two types of fatal encounters. Civilian-death events *reduce* trust in state institutions by 0.064 standard deviations, with similar declines in trust in the armed forces (i.e., police and military) and the government. Police-officer-death events instead *increase* institutional trust by 0.032 standard deviations, again with similar effects across state institutions. Neither type of event has a detectable effect on interpersonal trust. The contrast indicates that the results reflect changes in citizens' assessments of the state rather than a general deterioration or improvement in social trust. The null effects in surveys without fatal encounters provide a placebo check against the possibility that survey rollout patterns, rather than fatal encounters, drive our estimates.

We then examine the role of information transmission. For civilian-death events, the decline in institutional trust is concentrated among events covered by major national media within the 12-day post-event window. Events with delayed coverage generate no detectable trust response, including among respondents living in the municipality where the event occurred. By contrast, when media coverage is timely, the decline in trust is substantially larger among local respondents. Because the timing of media coverage is not randomly assigned, we complement this evidence with a separate analysis of competing news. Using exact-date natural disasters from the Emergency Events Database (EM-DAT) as unrelated shocks to domestic media attention, we show that disaster pressure reduces the daily probability that a fatal encounter receives its first national-media report by about 1.51 percentage points, approximately 36 percent of the baseline reporting hazard. The displacement effect is sim-

ilar for both events. Together, these results are consistent with information diffusion being central to how violent police–civilian encounters affect institutional trust.

Our work relates first to the broad literature on trust and social capital. Since Arrow (1972), a large literature has documented the importance of trust for economic exchange and development (Guiso et al., 2004, 2009; Tabellini, 2010; Algan and Cahuc, 2010; Lowes and Montero, 2021), as well as for political outcomes (Algan et al., 2017; Nunn et al., 2026). Social capital can also improve the functioning of political institutions by facilitating information diffusion and electoral accountability (Ponzetto and Troiano, 2025). It is important, however, to distinguish trust in other people from trust in institutions. These are related but conceptually and empirically distinct attitudes: recent evidence explicitly identifies interpersonal trust and institutional trust as separate dimensions of social capital (Durante et al., 2025). Much of the economic literature on trust focuses on interpersonal trust because of its role in exchange, cooperation, and social interactions. Our object of interest is instead citizens' confidence in state institutions. This distinction also motivates our use of interpersonal trust as a secondary outcome. More broadly, our analysis relates to work studying how trust is shaped by domestic conflict (Rohner et al., 2013; Bauer et al., 2016), income and financial security (Butler et al., 2016; Ananyev and Guriev, 2019; Beltramo et al., 2024), information (Acemoglu et al., 2020; Khan et al., 2021; Braccioli et al., 2025), and historical experience (Nunn and Wantchekon, 2011; Buggle and Durante, 2021).

We also contribute to a growing literature on the consequences of the state's use of force to provide public safety. Exposure to violent police activity, including aggressive policing and shootings, has been linked to lower community engagement and cooperation with public authorities (Baumer, 2002; Desmond et al., 2016; Zoorob, 2020; Mikdash and Zaiour, 2024; Ang et al., 2025), increased political mobilization (Ang and Tebes, 2024), and lower academic performance among nearby students (Gershenson and Hayes, 2018; Legewie and Fagan, 2019; Ang, 2021; González and Prem, 2024). These findings illustrate that police violence can have political and social consequences extending far beyond the immediate victims. Our empirical analysis focuses on one mechanism that can connect these outcomes: changes in citizens' confidence in the institutions exercising state authority.[2]

We make four contributions. First, we provide multi-country causal evidence that high-profile civilian-death events reduce institutional trust, directly supporting the interpretation that diminished confidence in the state can help explain the lower cooperation documented in the United States after citizens experience events related to police violence (Ang et al.,

[2]Moreno-Medina et al. (2025) show that linguistic features of news coverage, such as passive voice or omission of the perpetrator, shape perceived responsibility for police killings. Motivated by this insight, we also examine how headlines frame police–civilian fatal encounters.

2025). Second, we document the opposite response when police officers are killed by civilians. Evidence on the consequences of police-officer deaths is much more limited, and, to our knowledge, no previous work has studied their effects on citizens' trust in the state.[3] Third, we provide evidence on the information mechanism: trust responses are concentrated among events that receive timely national coverage, and unrelated shocks to competing news delay that coverage. Fourth, we extend the economics literature on police–civilian interactions beyond the United States to seventeen Latin American countries, settings characterized by substantial variation in violence, policing, and institutional capacity. This cross-country perspective allows us to study whether the political consequences of salient interactions between citizens and state agents extend across markedly different institutional environments.

2 Data Construction

2.1 Cross-national representative surveys

We measure trust in state institutions using two major public opinion surveys across Latin America. The first is the *Latin American Public Opinion Project* (LAPOP), which conducts nationally representative surveys approximately every two years and includes detailed questions on citizens' experiences with and perceptions of political institutions, public security, and the police. The second is *Latinobarómetro*, which conducts nationally representative surveys throughout Latin America and provides consistent measures of political attitudes and institutional trust. Crucially for our research design, fieldwork in both surveys takes place over several weeks, generating within-survey variation in respondents' interview dates.

We harmonized all available waves of LAPOP and Latinobarómetro between 2000 and 2024. We aligned questions on institutional trust, socioeconomic characteristics, and geographic identifiers across countries and waves, harmonizing response scales and variable definitions. We also collected the exact interview date for each respondent, allowing us to link survey responses to contemporaneous events at the daily level. Our analysis focuses on three measures of institutional trust: trust in state institutions, the armed forces (i.e. military and police), and the government. These outcomes capture related but distinct evaluations of public authority and allow us to assess whether any response is concentrated in institutions directly associated with the use of force (armed forces) or extends to government more broadly. We also harmonize a measure of interpersonal trust where available. As discussed below, we use this last outcome as secondary outcome to distinguish changes in

[3]Previous work shows that when a police officer dies on duty, other officers adjust their arrest behavior in a manner consistent with increased fear (Cho et al., 2024).

evaluations of the state from more general changes in citizens' willingness to trust others.

Overall, the harmonized data contain nearly 623,000 survey responses across seventeen countries. This is comparable in size to observing a survey with roughly 1,500 respondents in each of the seventeen countries in every year between 2000 and 2024. Figure 1 summarizes the timing of survey fieldwork across countries. The average respondent is 40 years old, 52% are women, and approximately one-fifth have more than 12 years of education.

2.2 High-profile civilian-death and police-officer-death events

We constructed a new dataset of high-profile fatal encounters between civilians and police officers. We define a *civilian-death event* as an event in which police officers kill one or more civilians, and a *police-officer-death event* as an event in which civilians kill one or more police officers.[4] Because our design links the timing of these events to ongoing survey interviews, identifying the precise date and circumstances of each event is essential. We constructed the dataset through a standardized multi-step protocol based on manual searches of national news sources. For each country–year, we searched Google News using keywords related to fatal encounters involving civilians and police officers, adapting the searches to country-specific terminology. We reviewed the retrieved articles and recorded an event when it corresponded to one of the two categories defined above.[5] For each event, we recorded its exact date and location (i.e., municipality), the circumstances surrounding the encounter (e.g., protest, robbery, or police operation), and links to the articles documenting it.[6]

A key feature of the data construction is manual verification. Automated news databases such as GDELT provide broad coverage, but their source corpora can vary across countries and over time (Wang et al., 2016). Moreover, dates recorded by GDELT do not always coincide with the actual publication dates of the underlying news articles (Hopp et al., 2019). Measurement error in event dates would be particularly problematic for our research design. We therefore manually reviewed the underlying articles to distinguish the event date from the publication date and to verify that each case corresponded to a police–civilian fatal encounter.[7] Across seventeen countries, our data include 196 civilian-death events from 2000

[4]For off-duty officers, we retain only incidents linked to their role as state agents, such as targeted attacks on police, crimes or robberies, organized crime, or mass gatherings and protests.

[5]To focus on events that entered the national media environment, we retained only cases reported by at least one of five major national media outlets in each country, which we defined ex ante.

[6]Google News results reflect its index and ranking at the time of search, both of which may change over time (Engelmann et al., 2021). We searched for events in two different waves: for civilian events in 2020–2022, covering 2000–2021, and police-officer events in 2024–2025, covering 2000–2024.

[7]Each event was cross-verified across multiple sources to confirm its date and nature, and ambiguous

to 2021 and 1,070 police-officer-death events from 2000 to 2024.

Our article-level data separate event occurrence from information arrival and comprise 681 articles documenting civilian-death events and 2,305 documenting police-officer-death events. For each of the major national outlets, we record whether the event is reported and the date on which coverage first appears. We can therefore measure both the breadth of coverage across outlets and the delay between the fatal encounter and its entry into the national media environment. This distinction is important for our analysis: the event date determines exposure in the baseline research design, whereas publication dates allow us to study whether the trust response depends on when information reaches the public. They also provide the outcome used in our analysis of competing news in Section 5.

By construction, these data do not represent the universe of fatal encounters between civilians and police. Instead, they capture events that enter the national media environment. This distinction defines the population to which our estimates apply: we study how exposure to high-profile police-civilian fatal encounters affects citizens' attitudes toward the state. The probability that an event enters this information environment may vary across countries, over time, and with event characteristics. Our empirical specifications absorb differences in the country-specific environment across survey waves, but our results should nevertheless be interpreted as applying to high-profile events rather than to all police–civilian fatalities. We examine the characteristics and media coverage of these events in the next section.

2.3 Characteristics of high-profile events

The dataset contains substantially more police-officer-death events than civilian-death events: 1,070 compared with 196 overall, and 860 compared with 196 in the same 2000-2021 period. This difference may reflect both variation in the underlying frequency of these encounters and differences in which events enter the national media environment.[8] Table 1 summarizes the circumstances and media coverage of the events. Civilian-death events involve 3.4 deaths on average and frequently occur during protests (38%), while organized crime is involved in 7% of cases. In contrast, police-officer-death events typically involve fewer deaths (1.5 on average), are rarely associated with protests, and are substantially more likely to involve organized crime (60%). Police officers are on duty in most events of both types.

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or duplicate entries were excluded. When discrepancies appeared, we retained only cases with consistent information in at least two independent sources. We also verified that the event date preceded or coincided with the publication date and that the location corresponded to an identifiable administrative unit.

[8]Figure A1 shows substantial cross-country variation in the ratio of police-officer-death to civilian-death events, although police-officer-death events are more common in the majority of countries.

The two event types also differ in how they enter the media environment. Civilian-death events are covered by more major national outlets on average (3.5 compared with 2.2), whereas police-officer-death events tend to receive coverage more quickly: 94% are covered within 12 days of the event, compared with 69% of civilian-death events. Table 1 also compares events that occur during survey fieldwork with those occurring outside it. Most observable characteristics are similar across the two groups, although events occurring during survey fieldwork are more likely to take place during protests. We return to the comparability of events and respondents around survey fieldwork in Section 3.

To characterize how these events are portrayed, we also code the semantic content of the news headlines. Table A1 shows marked differences across event types. Headlines describing civilian-death events are more likely to focus on the victim (63%), whereas headlines describing police-officer-death events are more likely to focus on the perpetrator (73%). References to the state or its security forces are also substantially more common in headlines about police-officer-death events (79%) than in those about civilian-death events (37%). For comparison, only 2% of headlines describing civilian-on-civilian killings in GDELT mention the state. These patterns indicate that police-civilian fatal encounters are presented to readers in ways that directly identify state actors and distinguish them from other violent events.

3 Research Design

To estimate the effect of high-profile police–civilian fatal encounters on trust, we exploit variation in event timing relative to survey fieldwork. When an event occurs while a survey is being conducted, respondents interviewed just before and just after the event provide a natural comparison within the same country and survey. Figure 1 illustrates this design. Across all surveys, 22 civilian-death events and 101 police-officer-death events occur during fieldwork. To assess whether this overlap is unusual, we conduct a simulation exercise using a daily country-level panel. We randomly reassign event dates within countries 1,000 times and calculate how many simulated events overlap with survey fieldwork under the same sampling rules used in the empirical analysis. Figure A2 shows that the observed number of overlaps lies well within the simulated distribution for both event types. This evidence is consistent with the timing of high-profile events being unrelated to the survey schedule.

The simulation assesses whether events systematically coincide with survey fieldwork, but it cannot validate the design's identifying assumption: respondents interviewed immediately before and after an event must be comparable. Geographic sequencing could undermine this comparability if interview timing is associated with respondent or municipality characteristics (Muñoz et al., 2020). We therefore assess balance in respondent, municipality, and survey

characteristics, and use surveys without events as placebos to support our design.

Figure A3 compares observable characteristics of respondents and their municipalities before and after events. Differences are generally small, with only five characteristics statistically significant at the 5% level.[9] The composition of events overlapping survey fieldwork is also broadly similar to that of the remaining events. Table 1 shows that events occurring during fieldwork are more likely to take place during protests for both event types, while most other observable characteristics are similar. Table A2 shows some differences in headline framing for civilian-death events occurring during fieldwork, whereas headline characteristics for police-officer-death events are highly similar. These differences affect the composition of events for which our design is available, but not the within-event comparison between respondents interviewed immediately before and after an event.

We construct the estimating sample by restricting attention to respondents interviewed within ±12 days of an event. The narrow window limits comparisons to respondents interviewed under similar political and economic conditions and reduces the scope for slow-moving confounders to generate differences across the event date. At the same time, it provides enough observations on either side of the event to estimate the effects with reasonable precision. Our results are not specific to this choice: Section 4 reports estimates across alternative bandwidths. Of the events occurring during survey fieldwork, 20 civilian-death events and 65 police-officer-death events enter the final estimating sample.[10]

We estimate, separately for civilian-death and police-officer-death events:

$$Y_{ics} = \beta T_{ics} + \gamma X_i + \phi_{cs} + \varepsilon_{ics}, \tag{1}$$

where Y_{ics} denotes an outcome for respondent i in country c and survey s. The indicator T_{ics} equals one if the respondent's interview took place after the corresponding event and zero if it took place before. The vector X_i includes controls for gender, age, two education indicators, and computer ownership, while ϕ_{cs} denotes country-by-survey fixed effects. Identification therefore comes from variation in interview timing within the same country and survey around the event date. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level, where regions correspond to harmonized first-level administrative units.

Our main outcomes are standardized measures of trust in state institutions, the armed forces, and the government. We also examine standardized interpersonal trust as secondary

[9]Figure A4 further shows balance in survey implementation characteristics around event dates.

[10]Table A3 compares events included in the estimating sample (20 and 65 for civilian and police-officer events) with those excluded (2 and 36). Events are excluded when they overlap with an earlier event within the same survey or do not generate sufficient usable observations within the ±12-day window.

outcome. Under the assumption that event timing relative to respondents' interview dates is as good as random conditional on controls and fixed effects, β identifies the causal effect of being interviewed after a high-profile event within the $\pm$12-day window. Because information about an event need not reach the public immediately, this is a reduced-form effect of event occurrence; we examine the role of media coverage and information diffusion below.

4 Police–Civilian Fatalities and Trust in the State

Table 2 reports the effects of fatal encounters on trust. Panel A presents estimates for civilian-death events and Panel B for police-officer-death events. Columns (1)-(3) report standardized trust in state institutions, the armed forces, and the government, while column (4) reports interpersonal trust. The results reveal a clear asymmetry. Following a civilian-death event, trust in state institutions declines by 0.064 standard deviations. The effect is similar for trust in the armed forces (-0.083) and the government (-0.057), and all three estimates are statistically significant. In contrast, police-officer-death events increase trust in state institutions by 0.032 standard deviations, with comparable increases in trust in the armed forces (0.028) and the government (0.035). Although smaller in magnitude than the effects of civilian-death events, the estimates consistently point in the opposite direction.[11]

The documented effects on trust are specific to attitudes toward the state. Column (4) of Table 2 shows no statistically significant effect on interpersonal trust: the estimates are -0.011 following civilian-death events and -0.021 following police-officer-death events.[12] More broadly, civilian-death events have no detectable effect on satisfaction with democracy or political ideology. Police-officer-death events generate a small rightward shift in political ideology but again with no detectable change in satisfaction with democracy (Table A6).

The opposite signs for civilian and police-officer events are informative because neither response is predetermined. A civilian-death event may be interpreted as evidence of abuse or weak accountability, but it could instead increase trust if the use of force is viewed as effective action against a dangerous offender. Likewise, a police-officer-death event may heighten the demand for public order, but it could also reduce trust by revealing the state's inability to provide security. The results are therefore consistent with citizens interpreting the two types of events as distinct signals: civilian-death events as adverse information about state

[11] Figures A5 and A6 provide a nonparametric view of the corresponding dynamics, plotting average trust by interview day relative to civilian-death and police-officer-death events. The figures complement the estimates in Table 2 without imposing the before-after functional form used in equation (1).

[12] Table A4 yields the same conclusion when using as outcome an indicator for low trust, while Table A5 shows that the results are robust to alternative ways of aggregating the institutional-trust measures.

conduct and police-officer-death events as information about threats to public order.

Robustness. The main findings are robust across a broad set of specifications and placebo exercises. Estimates remain similar when varying the window around the event (Figures A7 and A8), excluding each event in turn (Figures A9 and A10), and excluding the countries with the highest ratios of police-officer-death to civilian-death events (Table A7). They are also robust to alternative clustering (Table A8), survey sampling weights (Table A9), and randomization inference (Table A10). In adition, Table A11 shows no systematic pattern of differential item nonresponse that could account for the main results.

Two placebo exercises further support the design. Randomly assigning event dates within survey fieldwork generates estimates centered around zero (Figures A11 and A12). Similarly, assigning events to the corresponding dates in either the previous survey wave produces no detectable effects (Table A12). Together, these exercises make it unlikely that the results arise mechanically from survey timing, geographic sequencing (Muñoz et al., 2020), or persistent country-specific patterns around the calendar dates on which the actual events occurred.

Protest activity is a particularly relevant concern for civilian-death events: protests may both precipitate confrontations with police and affect attitudes toward the state independently. Table A13 therefore examines civilian-death events separately in settings without recent protest activity and during protest episodes. Reassuringly, the negative effects on institutional trust are similar across the two samples. Figure A13 presents the corresponding dynamics by protest activity. These results indicate that the decline in trust following civilian-death events is not driven by contemporaneous protest activity.

Heterogeneity. Finally, we examine whether the effects vary systematically across institutional, respondent, and event characteristics. Table A14 finds little evidence that the effects depend on the quality of democracy, recent violence, or baseline institutional trust. Table A15 considers years under dictatorship, respondent ideology, and geographic distance. While some individual interactions are statistically significant—most notably by ideology for civilian-death events and by distance to the event in several specifications—there is no uniform pattern of heterogeneity across outcomes and event types. Tables A16 and A17 further examine event characteristics and media content. We return to the role of media coverage, where the evidence is considerably more systematic, in the next section.

5 Media Coverage and Information Transmission

A natural explanation for the effects documented above is that police–civilian fatal encounters change beliefs when information about them reaches the public. We examine this

mechanism in two steps. First, we ask whether the trust response depends on how quickly an event is covered by major national media. Second, we test whether unrelated shocks to competing news affect the speed with which fatal encounters are reported.

5.1 Timing of media coverage and trust

Our baseline specification assigns treatment according to the date of the event, but coverage by major national media need not occur immediately. We say a civilian-death event receives *early media coverage* if at least one of the five major national media outlets reports it within 12 days of the event, and as receiving *delayed media coverage* otherwise. This threshold corresponds to the post-event window in our main specification. Of the 20 civilian-death events in the estimating sample, 14 receive early coverage and six receive delayed coverage.

The timing of coverage is not randomly assigned. Table A18 compares civilian-death events with early and delayed coverage. The two groups are similar along several observable dimensions, although early-covered events are more likely to occur during protests. Delayed events also involve more deaths, although this difference is imprecise. We therefore interpret this exercise as descriptive evidence on whether the trust response depends on the timing of information arrival, rather than as causal evidence on the effect of media coverage itself.

Table 3 presents the results. Panel A restricts the sample to civilian-death events with early media coverage. The estimates are close to, and if anything somewhat larger than, the baseline effects: trust in state institutions falls by 0.075 standard deviations, trust in the armed forces by 0.095, and trust in the government by 0.063. The dynamics are also visible in Figure A5. Panels B and C examine whether these effects differ for respondents living in the same municipality as the event. For events with delayed coverage, the post-event coefficients are small and statistically insignificant, and there is no evidence of a larger response among respondents in the same municipality. In contrast, early-covered events generate substantially larger declines in trust among respondents living in the same municipality. The interaction coefficients are -0.159 for trust in state institutions, -0.228 for the armed forces, and -0.099 for the government. Thus, geographic proximity amplifies the trust response only when the event also enters the national media environment within 12 days. This pattern suggests that local salience alone is insufficient to generate the larger response and is consistent with national media coverage reinforcing information available locally.[13]

[13]Most police-officer-death events also receive early media coverage. Table A19 shows that restricting the sample to these events produces estimates close to the baseline results in Table 2. Unfortunately, there is insufficient local variation to estimate the corresponding municipality interactions precisely.

5.2 Competing news and the timing of media coverage

We next test whether unrelated competing news affects how quickly fatal encounters enter the national information environment. We measure competing domestic news using the Emergency Events Database (EM-DAT), maintained by the Centre for Research on the Epidemiology of Disasters at UCLouvain (Delforge et al., 2025; CRED, 2026). The approach builds on evidence that newsworthy events compete for limited media attention (Eisensee and Strömberg, 2007; Durante and Zhuravskaya, 2018). We retain sudden natural disasters in our seventeen countries for which an exact start date is available—floods, storms, mass movements and landslides, volcanic activity, and wildfires—yielding 1,199 eligible disasters in 1990-2024. We combine these data with outlet-specific publication dates and construct a discrete-time risk set for first media coverage. For each fatal encounter e and major national outlet o, the risk set begins on the date of the event and continues until the outlet first reports the event or until 12 days after the event, whichever comes first. Let R_{eoct} equal one if outlet o first reports event e, occurring in country c, on calendar day t, and zero on preceding days for which the outlet remains at risk of first reporting the event. Outlets that do not report an event within the 12-day window contribute zeros throughout their risk set.

We measure disaster pressure conservatively to ensure that competing news precedes the reporting decision. Let D_{ct} equal one if an eligible natural-disaster episode was active in country c on the calendar day preceding t. We treat each disaster as an eight-day episode, beginning on its recorded start date and continuing for seven additional days. Consequently, a disaster beginning on date t generates competing-news pressure on reporting dates $t+1$ through $t+8$, but not on date t itself. This convention avoids imposing an ordering between disaster onset and media reporting when both are observed only at the daily frequency. Our preferred heterogeneous specification is the following linear probability model:

$$R_{eoct} = \beta D_{ct} + \delta \left(D_{ct} \times Civilian_e\right) + \alpha_e + \lambda_{cok(e)} + \rho_{k(e)\tau} + \mu_{ck(e)w} + \varepsilon_{eoct}, \qquad (2)$$

where $Civilian_e$ equals one for civilian-death events and zero for police-officer-death events, and $k(e)$ denotes the event type. The term α_e denotes event fixed effects; $\lambda_{cok(e)}$ denotes country-by-outlet-by-event-type fixed effects; $\rho_{k(e)\tau}$ denotes event-type-by-relative-day fixed effects, where τ is the number of days since the fatal encounter; and $\mu_{ck(e)w}$ denotes country-by-event-type-by-weekday fixed effects. Event fixed effects absorb all time-invariant characteristics of a fatal encounter, including its severity, location, and underlying newsworthiness. Event-type-by-relative-day fixed effects flexibly capture differences in the baseline reporting hazard over the days following an event, while the remaining fixed effects absorb persistent differences across outlets and systematic weekday patterns. Identification therefore comes

from within-event changes in disaster pressure over the days during which an outlet remains at risk of first reporting the event.[14]

In equation (2), β captures the effect of disaster pressure on the daily first-report probability for police-officer-death events, while $\beta+\delta$ gives the corresponding effect for civilian-death events. The coefficient δ therefore tests whether the displacement effect differs across the two event types. Column (1) of Table 4 estimates the pooled effect imposing $\delta = 0$, while columns (2)–(4) report the police-officer-death effect, the civilian-death effect, and their difference from equation (2), respectively. Because disaster pressure varies at the country-by-day level, we cluster conventional standard errors by country. With only seventeen countries, we additionally report country-level wild-cluster-bootstrap p-values based on 9,999 Rademacher draws and treat these as our preferred inference.

Table 4 shows that competing domestic news substantially reduces the probability that a fatal encounter is first reported. Pooling both event types, disaster pressure lowers the daily first-report probability by 1.51 percentage points. Relative to a baseline daily reporting hazard of 4.18 percent, this represents a reduction of approximately 36 percent. Conventional country-clustered inference rejects a zero effect at conventional levels, while the preferred wild-cluster-bootstrap yields a p-value of 0.077. The displacement effect is similar across event types. Disaster pressure reduces the first-report probability by 1.53 percentage points for police-officer-death events and by 1.34 percentage points for civilian-death events. The difference is only 0.19 percentage points and is statistically indistinguishable from zero (wild-bootstrap $p = 0.924$). Thus, unrelated congestion in the domestic news environment materially affects when police–civilian fatal encounters receive national coverage.

Taken together with Table 3, these results provide complementary evidence for an information transmission mechanism: changes in trust are concentrated among events that enter the national media environment during the relevant post-event window, while the speed at which events enter that environment responds to unrelated competing news.

6 Conclusion

Who dies in a high-profile encounter between police and civilians matters for how citizens view the state. Across seventeen Latin American countries, trust in state institutions falls

[14]Recent work by Armona et al. (2026) measures newsworthiness using proper scoring rules based on the surprise of a realization relative to the prior distribution of underlying events. This approach cannot be implemented in our setting because our event universe is itself constructed from media reports, so the observed distribution of events is selected by the reporting process. Event fixed effects instead absorb time-invariant differences in the underlying newsworthiness of the events in our sample.

in the days following a civilian death and rises following the death of a police officer. These responses extend to confidence in the government itself. After a civilian death, the decline in trust is concentrated in cases that receive timely national news coverage. For those cases, the decline is particularly pronounced among people who live close to the encounter.

High-profile fatal encounters may help explain some of the short-run fluctuations in institutional trust observed in Latin America over recent decades. Their consequences extend beyond those directly involved. What begins as a local encounter can become national news within days, and the public response can extend to institutions far removed from the incident. By changing citizens' confidence in the state, these encounters may ultimately affect how effectively governments can carry out policies that depend on public cooperation.

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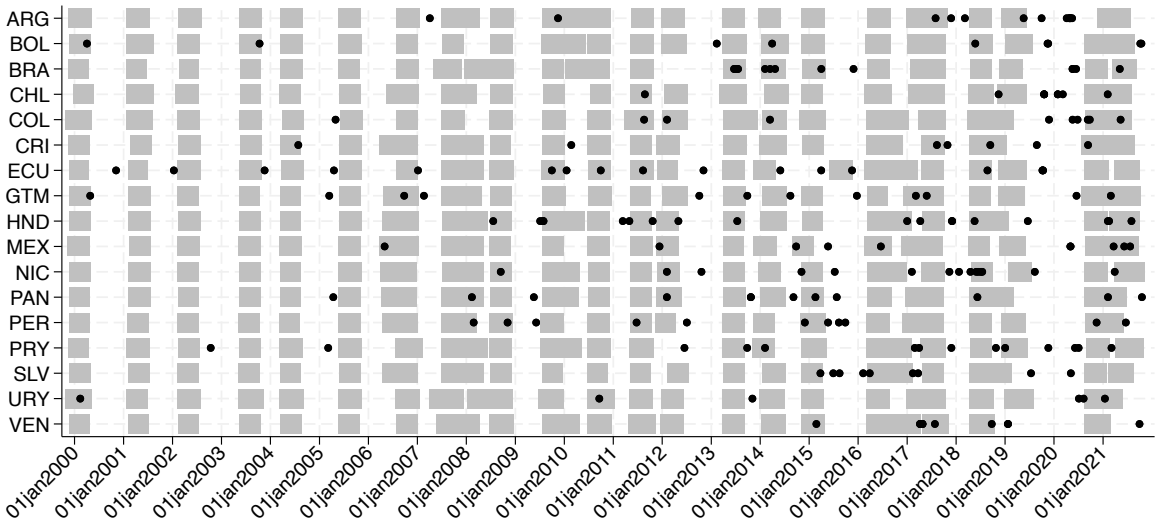
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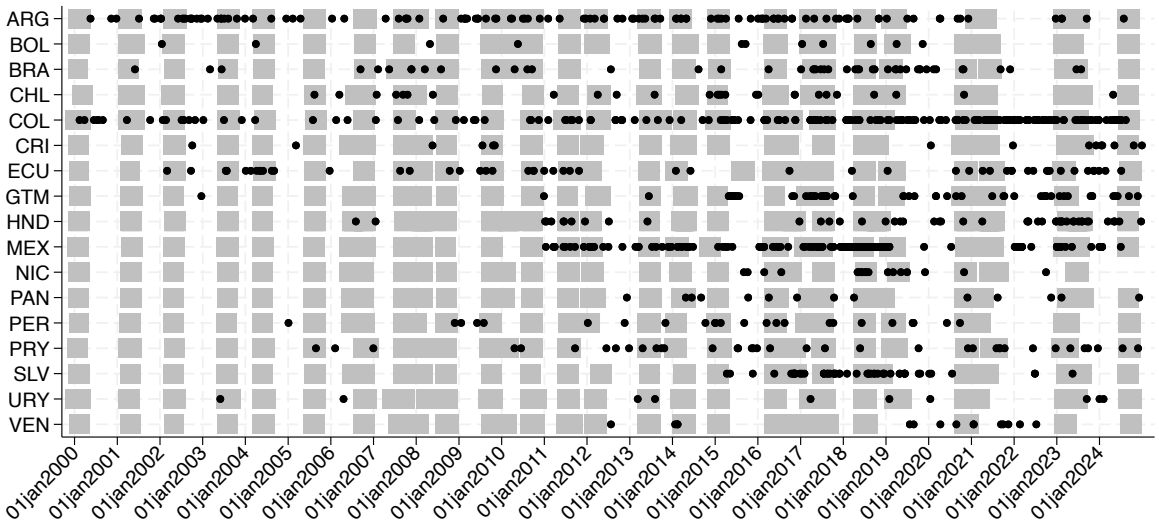
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Figure 1: Timing of survey fieldwork and high-profile fatalities



(a) Civilian-death events (N =196)



(b) Police-officer-death events (N =1,070)

Notes: The figure shows the timing of survey fieldwork and high-profile police–civilian fatalities in the 17 countries included in the sample between 2000 and 2021 in panel (a) and between 2000 and 2024 in panel (b). The y-axis lists countries and the x-axis shows calendar time. Gray bars indicate periods during which survey interviews were conducted in Latinobarómetro or LAPOP. Black dots denote high-profile fatalities. Panel (a) reports civilian deaths caused by police officers (N = 196), and panel (b) reports police-officer deaths caused by civilians (N = 1,070). For police-officer deaths, we include only incidents that received coverage in major national newspapers and that satisfy at least one of the following criteria: (i) the officer was on duty, (ii) the event was a targeted attack on police, (iii) organized crime was involved or a crime was taking place, or (iv) the incident occurred during a mass gathering or public protest.

Table 1: Characteristics of high-profile fatalities

	All	Outside survey	Within survey	Difference (3)–(2)
Panel A: Civilian-death events	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Number of deaths	3.429	3.391	3.727	0.336
	(7.718)	(7.619)	(8.653)	[0.848]
During protest	0.383	0.356	0.591	0.235
	(0.487)	(0.480)	(0.503)	[0.033]
Organized crime involved	0.071	0.075	0.045	-0.029
	(0.258)	(0.264)	(0.213)	[0.618]
Police officer was on duty	0.842	0.839	0.864	0.025
	(0.366)	(0.369)	(0.351)	[0.768]
Number of media outlets covering event	3.474	3.511	3.182	-0.330
	(1.341)	(1.316)	(1.532)	[0.279]
Covered by media within 12 days	0.689	0.686	0.714	0.028
	(0.464)	(0.465)	(0.463)	[0.793]
Headline: State mentioned	0.404	0.411	0.347	-0.064
	(0.370)	(0.368)	(0.388)	[0.436]
Headline: Focus on perpetrator	0.379	0.385	0.336	-0.049
	(0.370)	(0.368)	(0.394)	[0.553]
Observations	196	174	22	193
Panel B: Police-officer-death events				
Number of deaths	1.493	1.507	1.366	-0.140
	(1.649)	(1.703)	(0.997)	[0.416]
During protest	0.013	0.009	0.050	0.040
	(0.114)	(0.096)	(0.218)	[0.001]
Organized crime involved	0.600	0.598	0.624	0.026
	(0.490)	(0.491)	(0.487)	[0.609]
Police officer was on duty	0.719	0.719	0.713	-0.006
	(0.450)	(0.450)	(0.455)	[0.891]
Number of media outlets covering event	2.202	2.178	2.436	0.258
	(1.219)	(1.215)	(1.236)	[0.043]
Covered by media within 12 days	0.937	0.938	0.928	-0.011
	(0.242)	(0.241)	(0.260)	[0.682]
Headline: State mentioned	0.796	0.795	0.804	0.009
	(0.344)	(0.347)	(0.322)	[0.806]
Headline: Focus on perpetrator	0.722	0.722	0.729	0.007
	(0.384)	(0.386)	(0.364)	[0.862]
Observations	1070	969	101	1070

Notes: Summary statistics for high-profile police–civilian fatalities. Panel A reports civilian deaths caused by police; Panel B reports police-officer deaths caused by civilians. Columns (1)–(3) report means with standard deviations in parentheses for all events, events outside survey fieldwork, and events within survey fieldwork. Column (4) reports differences in means (within minus outside), with p-values in brackets. Headline variables are computed as the share of articles covering the event that mention the state or focus on the perpetrator. For civilian deaths, 22 events occur during survey fieldwork (20 used in estimation); for police-officer deaths, 101 events occur during survey fieldwork (65 used in estimation). Remaining events are excluded due to overlap within surveys or insufficient observations within the ±12-day window.

Table 2: High-profile police–civilian fatalities and trust

	Dep. variable: Standardized trust in ...			
	State institutions	Armed forces	Government	Interpersonal
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Panel A. Civilian-death events				
After *civilian death* event	-0.064***	-0.083***	-0.057**	-0.011
	(0.022)	(0.028)	(0.026)	(0.032)
Panel B. Police-officer-death events				
After *police-officer-death* event	0.032**	0.028*	0.035**	-0.021
	(0.015)	(0.016)	(0.018)	(0.018)
Observations (panel A)	13,593	13,593	12,961	13,329
Observations (panel B)	37,084	37,084	36,198	36,291
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1). The variable *After civilian-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which police officers killed one or more civilians, and zero otherwise. The variable *After police-officer-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which civilians killed one or more police officers, and zero otherwise. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding event. Columns (1)–(3) report trust in state institutions, the armed forces, and the government, respectively, while column (4) reports interpersonal trust. All trust measures are standardized to have mean zero and standard deviation one. All specifications include country-by-survey fixed effects and the following individual controls: gender, age, two education indicators, and computer ownership. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table 3: Media coverage and the effects of civilian-death events on trust

Dependent variable: Standardized trust in ...			
	State institutions	Armed forces	Government
Panel A. Early media coverage	(1)	(2)	(3)
After *civilian death* event	-0.075***	-0.097***	-0.063**
	(0.022)	(0.031)	(0.026)
Panel B. Delayed coverage and local effects			
After *civilian death* event	-0.045	-0.045	-0.069
	(0.068)	(0.069)	(0.081)
× Same municipality as event	0.074	0.038	0.124
	(0.071)	(0.075)	(0.082)
Same municipality as event	-0.181	-0.085	-0.269**
	(0.110)	(0.111)	(0.116)
Panel C. Early coverage and local effects			
After *civilian death* event	-0.067***	-0.087***	-0.056**
	(0.023)	(0.032)	(0.027)
× Same municipality as event	-0.159**	-0.228***	-0.099
	(0.072)	(0.082)	(0.072)
Same municipality as event	0.079	0.178*	-0.003
	(0.076)	(0.103)	(0.069)
Observations (panel A)	10,128	10,128	9,515
Observations (panel B)	3,465	3,465	3,446
Observations (panel C)	10,128	10,128	9,515
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1). Early media coverage refers to civilian-death events covered by major national media within 12 days of the event, while delayed media coverage refers to events not covered within 12 days. Panel A restricts the sample to events with early media coverage. Panels B and C examine heterogeneity by whether the respondent resides in the same municipality as the event, separately for events with delayed and early media coverage, respectively. The variable *After civilian-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which police officers killed one or more civilians, and zero otherwise. *Same municipality as event* equals one if the respondent resides in the same municipality in which the event occurred. All trust measures are standardized to have mean zero and standard deviation one. All specifications include country-by-survey fixed effects and the following individual controls: gender, age, two education indicators, and computer ownership. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table 4: Competing news and the timing of media coverage

	Pooled	Police-officer-death events	Civilian-death events	Difference (civilian−police)
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Disaster pressure	-0.015	-0.015	-0.013	0.002
	(0.006)	(0.007)	(0.013)	(0.016)
Country-clustered p-value	[0.019]	[0.022]	[0.310]	[0.905]
Wild-bootstrap p-value	[0.077]	[0.146]	[0.410]	[0.924]
Baseline daily reporting hazard	0.042	0.043	0.035	
Disaster-exposed events	146	131	15	
Events	1,266	1,070	196	
Risk-set observations	54,414	54,414	54,414	54,414
Event fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Country × outlet × event-type fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Event-type × relative-day fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Country × event-type × weekday fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The unit of observation is an event–outlet–day in the first-report risk set. For each fatal encounter and major national media outlet, the sample contains days 0 through 12 following the event until the outlet first reports the event. The dependent variable equals one on the day of first coverage and zero on preceding at-risk days. Disaster pressure equals one when an eligible sudden domestic natural disaster recorded in EM-DAT was active on the preceding calendar day. Thus, for a disaster beginning on date t, the main exposure window is $t + 1$ through $t + 8$. This timing convention ensures that the competing news event precedes the media-reporting decision. Eligible disasters include floods, storms, mass movements and landslides, volcanic activity, and wildfires. Column (1) imposes a common effect across civilian and police-officer fatalities. Columns (2)–(4) come from a pooled specification that interacts disaster pressure with an indicator for civilian deaths; column (4) reports the civilian-minus-police difference. All specifications include event fixed effects, country-by-outlet-by-event-type fixed effects, event-type-by-relative-day fixed effects, and country-by-event-type-by-weekday fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by country are reported in parentheses. The first p-value row reports two-sided p-values based on country-clustered standard errors. The second reports country-level wild-cluster-bootstrap p-values using Rademacher weights and 9,999 replications.

ONLINE APPENDIX

Police–Civilian Fatal Encounters and State Trust

Renata Canini *Felipe González* *Mounu Prem*

List of Figures

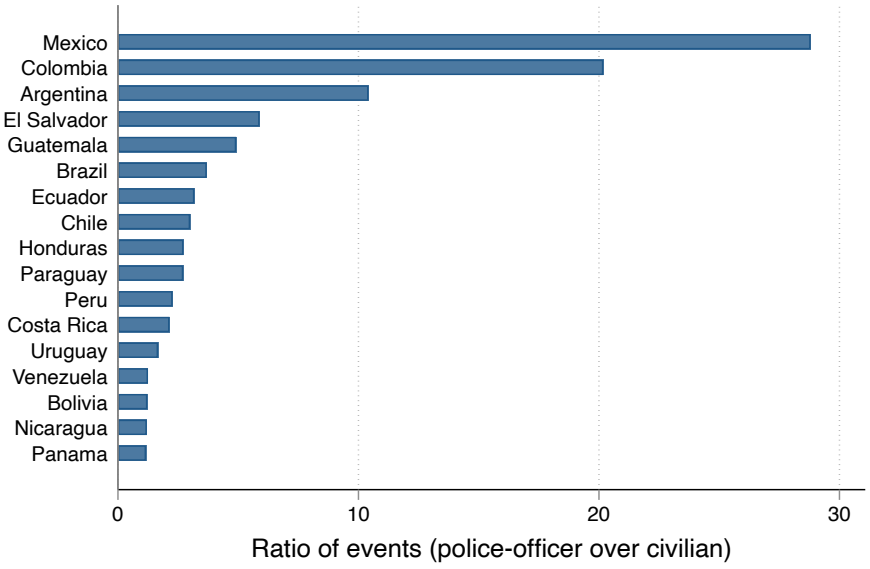
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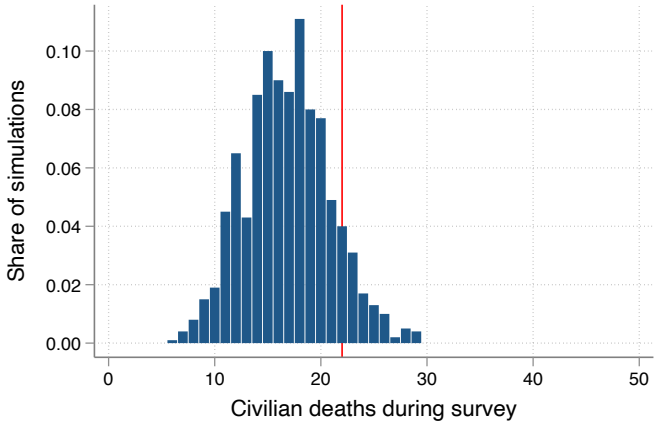
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Figure A1: Ratio of police to civilian events

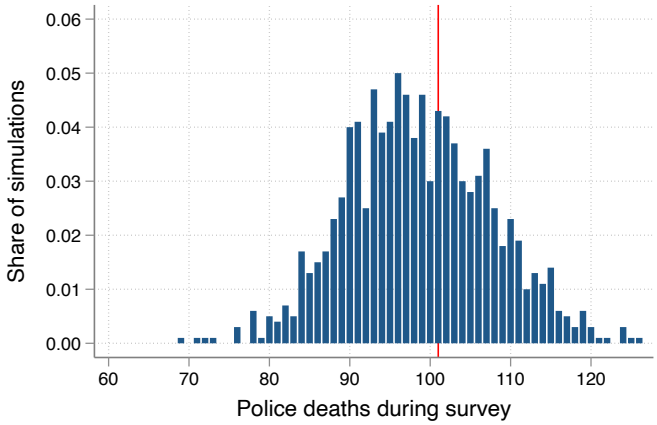


Notes: The figure reports, for each country in the sample, the ratio of police-officer death events to civilian death events. Countries are ordered by this ratio from lowest to highest. Each event corresponds to a distinct high-profile fatality recorded in our dataset. The figure highlights substantial cross-country variation in the relative frequency of these events.

Figure A2: Test for random timing of events



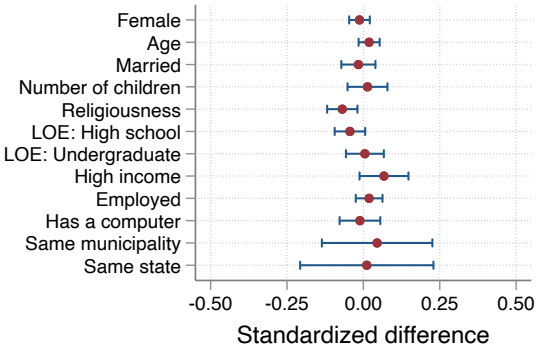
(a) Civilian-death events



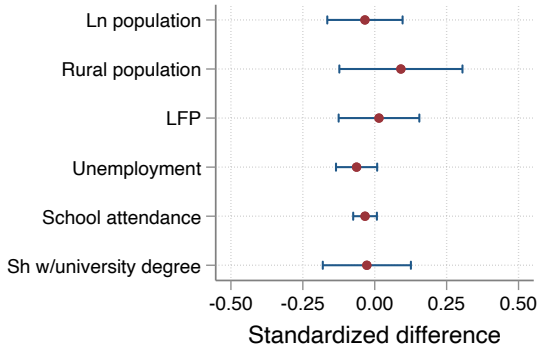
(b) Police-officer-death events

Notes: The figure tests whether the timing of high-profile fatalities relative to survey fieldwork is consistent with random timing. For each panel, we construct a daily country-level panel for the 17 countries in the sample and identify the days during which survey interviews were conducted. Panel (a) reports results for civilian deaths caused by police officers, and panel (b) for police-officer deaths caused by civilians. We then randomly reassign the observed number of fatalities within countries across days 1,000 times and count how many simulated events would overlap with survey fieldwork under the same rules used in the empirical analysis. In particular, an event is considered to overlap with a survey if it occurs during an ongoing survey spell, and only the first event within a survey spell is retained. The figure plots the distribution of simulated overlaps, while the vertical line indicates the observed number of overlaps in the data.

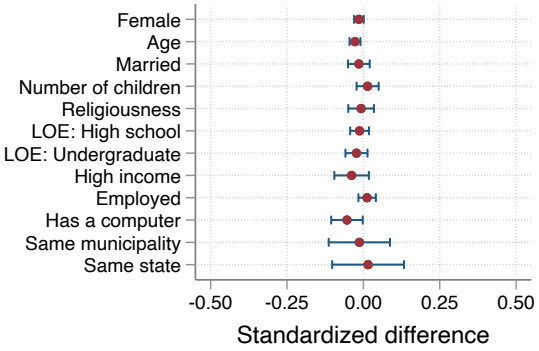
Figure A3: Balance in individual and municipality characteristics



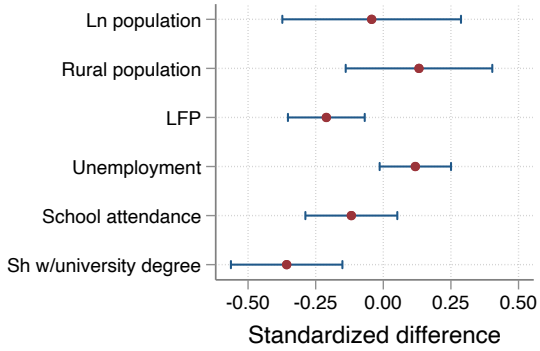
(a) Individual – Civilian-death events



(b) Municipality – Civilian-death events



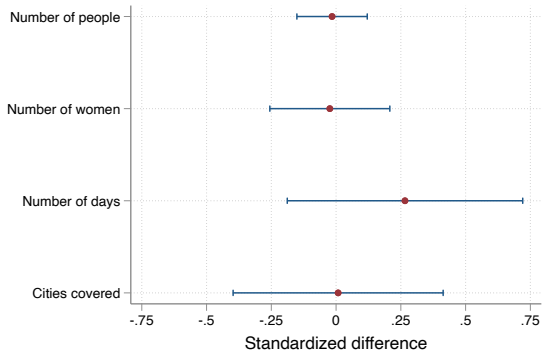
(c) Individual – Police-officer-death events



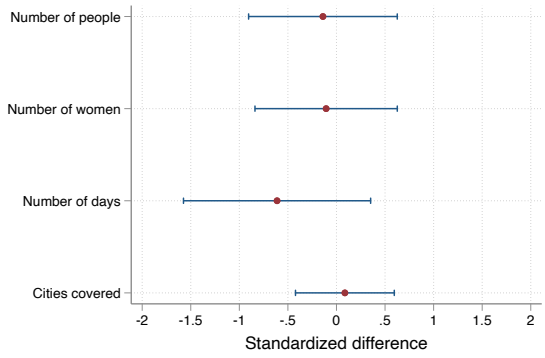
(d) Municipality – Police-officer-death events

Notes: The figure reports balance tests comparing respondents interviewed before and after high-profile fatalities. Each point shows the estimated coefficient from an OLS regression of the indicated individual or municipality characteristic on the treatment indicator (interviewed after the fatality), controlling for country-by-survey fixed effects. Horizontal lines represent 95% confidence intervals. All characteristics are standardized to have mean zero and unit standard deviation. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level. Panels (a) and (b) correspond to civilian deaths caused by police officers, while panels (c) and (d) correspond to police-officer deaths caused by civilians.

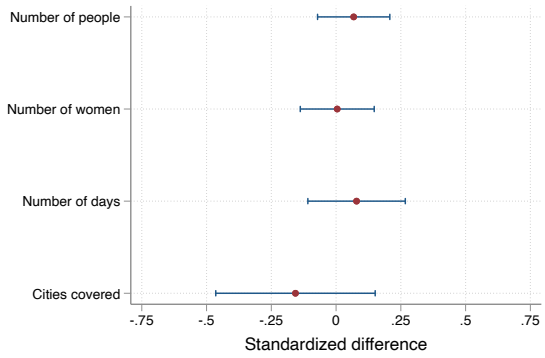
Figure A4: Balance in survey implementation



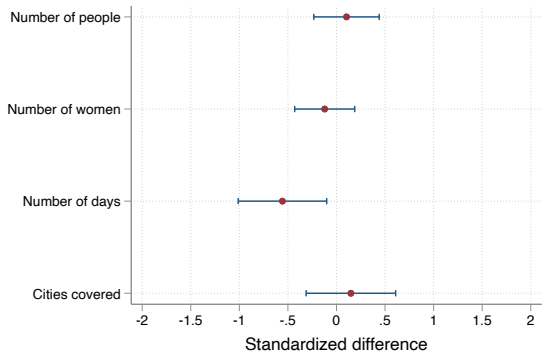
(a) Survey – Civilian-death events



(b) Implementation – Civilian-death events



(c) Survey – Police-officer-death events

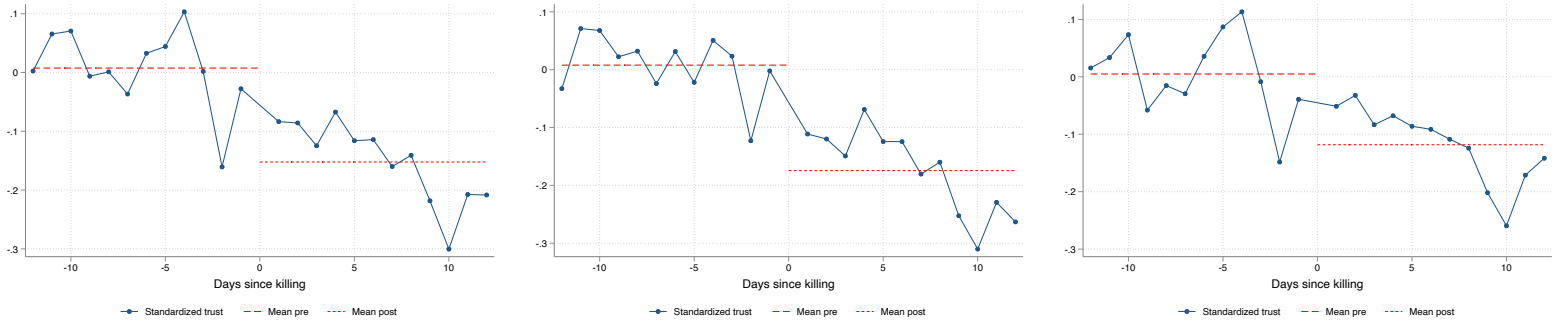


(d) Implementation – Police-officer-death events

Notes: The figure reports balance tests for survey implementation characteristics around high-profile fatalities. In panels (a) and (c), we use observations at the survey-country level and regress each of four survey characteristics on an indicator for whether the survey coincides with a civilian death event or a police-officer death event, reporting coefficients that control for country fixed effects and survey-year fixed effects. In panels (b) and (d), we compute each of the four characteristics using only the portion of the survey following the time of the event through the end of the survey. For surveys without a death, we compute each characteristic using the days after the date on which a death occurred in a survey conducted in the same country. When more than one survey in a given country was affected by a death, we repeat the procedure for the second event date. We then run a regression at the country-survey level on an indicator for whether a death occurred during the survey, including country fixed effects. Horizontal lines represent 95% confidence intervals based on robust standard errors. All characteristics are standardized to have mean zero and unit standard deviation. Panels (a) and (b) correspond to events with civilian deaths caused by police officers, while panels (c) and (d) correspond to events with police-officer deaths caused by civilians.

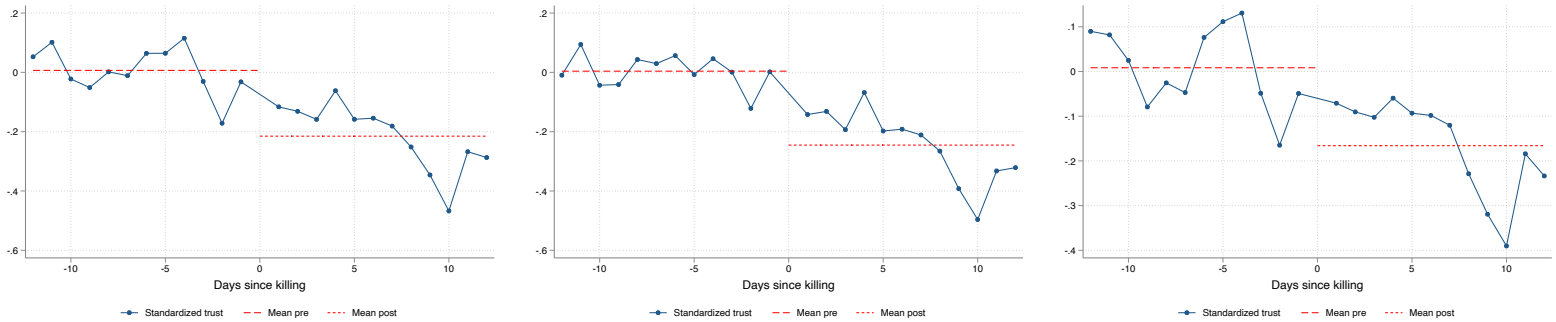
Figure A5: Dynamics of trust around civilian-death events

All civilian-death events



(a) State institutions (b) Armed forces (c) Government

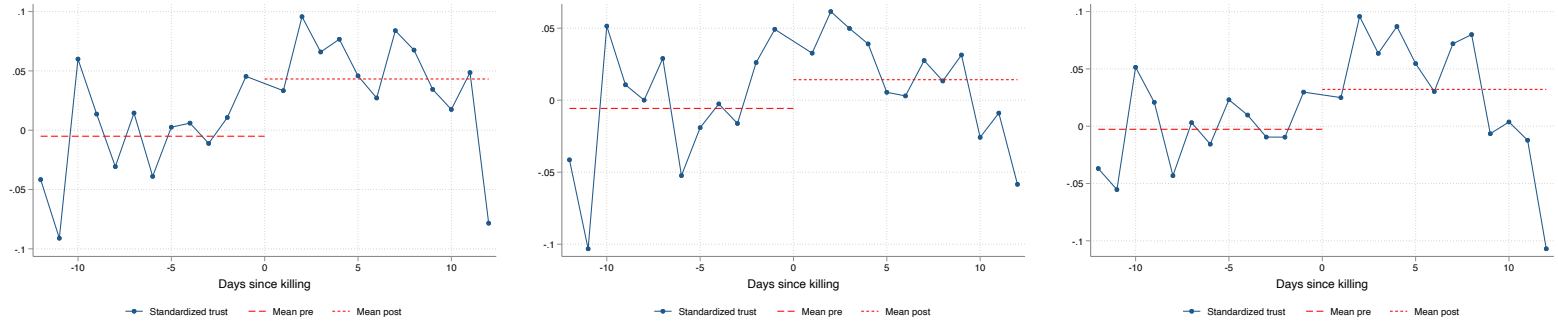
Early media coverage



(d) State institutions (e) Armed forces (f) Government

Notes: The figure presents the evolution of trust around civilian-death events. Panels (a)–(c) include all civilian-death events, while panels (d)–(f) restrict the sample to events with early media coverage, defined as coverage by major national media within 12 days of the event. Trust is standardized using the pre-event mean and standard deviation within the corresponding survey. Points report mean standardized trust by interview day relative to the event; horizontal lines report average trust before and after the event.

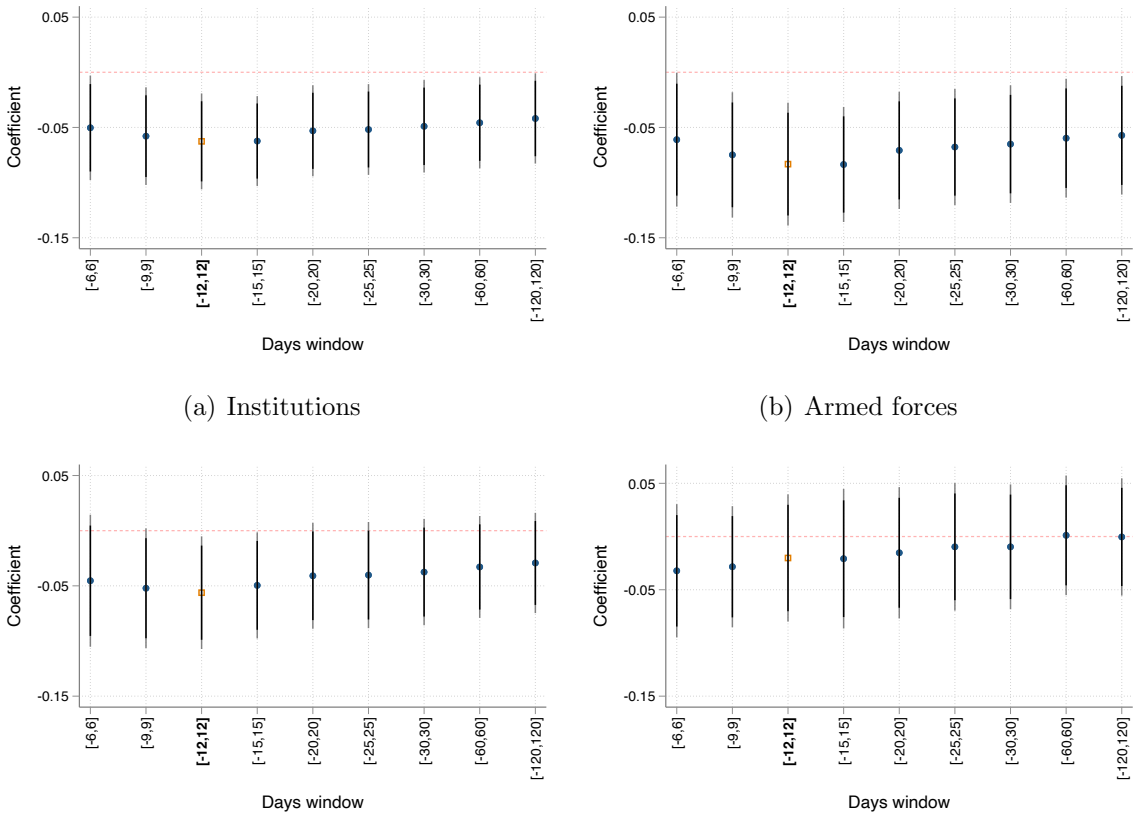
Figure A6: Dynamics of trust around police-officer-death events



(a) State institutions (b) Armed forces (c) Government

Notes: The figure presents the evolution of trust around police-officer-death events. Trust is standardized using the pre-event mean and standard deviation within the corresponding survey. Points report mean standardized trust by interview day relative to the event; horizontal lines report average trust before and after the event.

Figure A7: Robustness to bandwidth – Civilian-death events



(a) Institutions

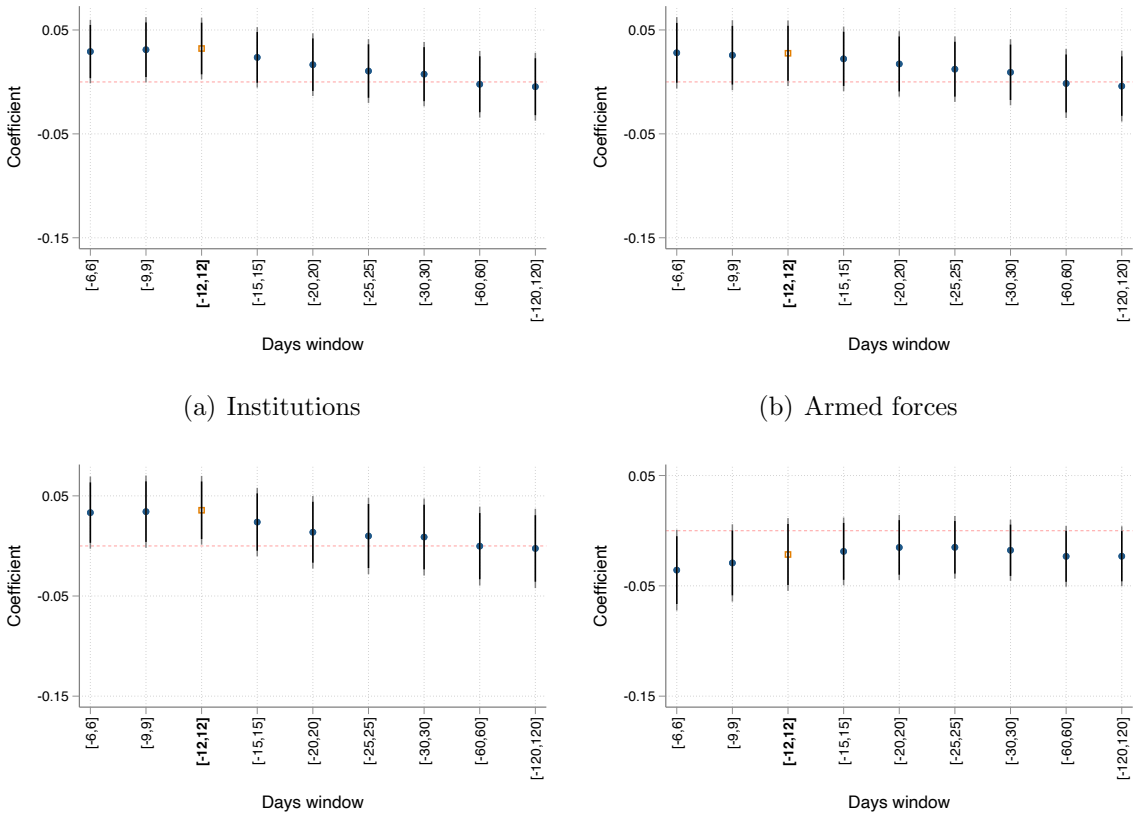
(b) Armed forces

(c) Government

(d) Interpersonal

Notes: The figure reports robustness of the estimated treatment effects to alternative time windows around high-profile civilian deaths caused by police officers. Each point shows the estimated coefficient from the baseline specification in Table 2, Panel A, using different symmetric interview windows around the event date. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level. Vertical lines represent 90% and 95% confidence intervals. The baseline specification uses a ±12-day window.

Figure A8: Robustness to bandwidth – Police-officer-death events



(a) Institutions

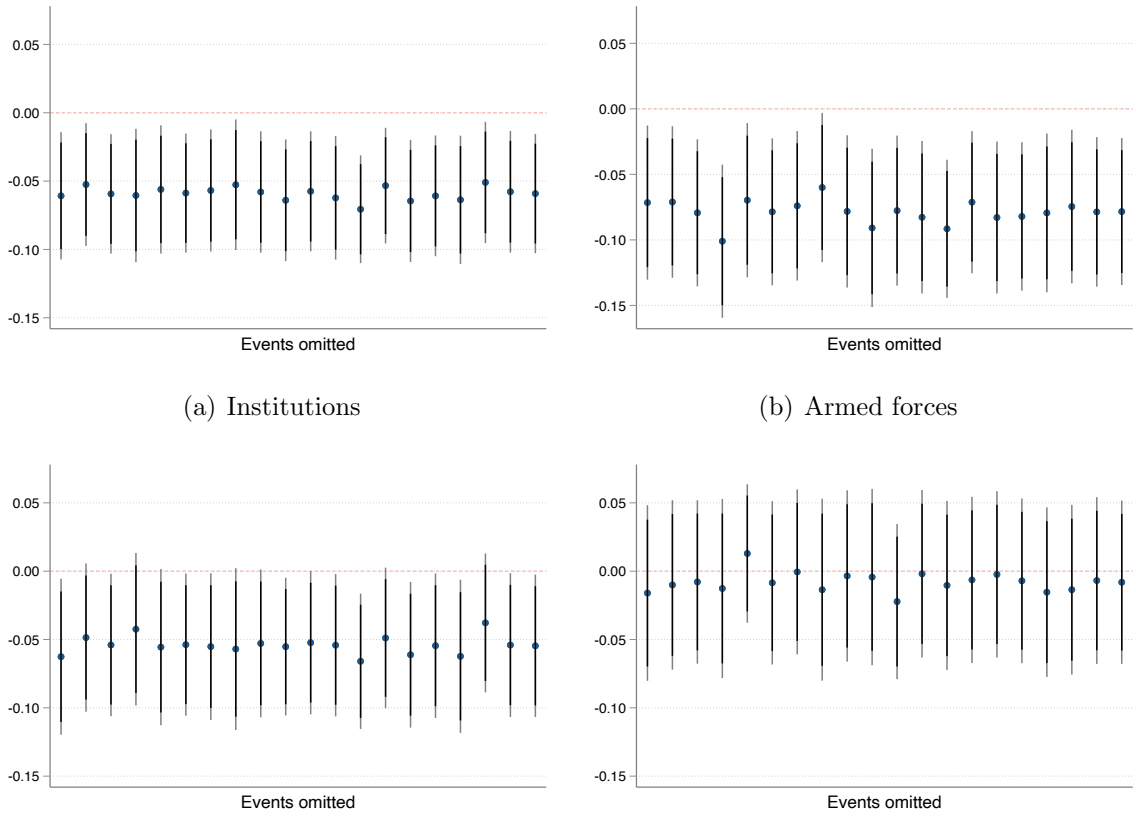
(b) Armed forces

(c) Government

(d) Interpersonal

Notes: The figure reports robustness of the estimated treatment effects to alternative time windows around high-profile police-officer deaths caused by civilians. Each point shows the estimated coefficient from the baseline specification in Table 2, Panel B, using different symmetric interview windows around the event date. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level. Vertical lines represent 90% and 95% confidence intervals. The baseline specification uses a ±12-day window.

Figure A9: Robustness to exclusion of individual events – Civilian-death events



(a) Institutions

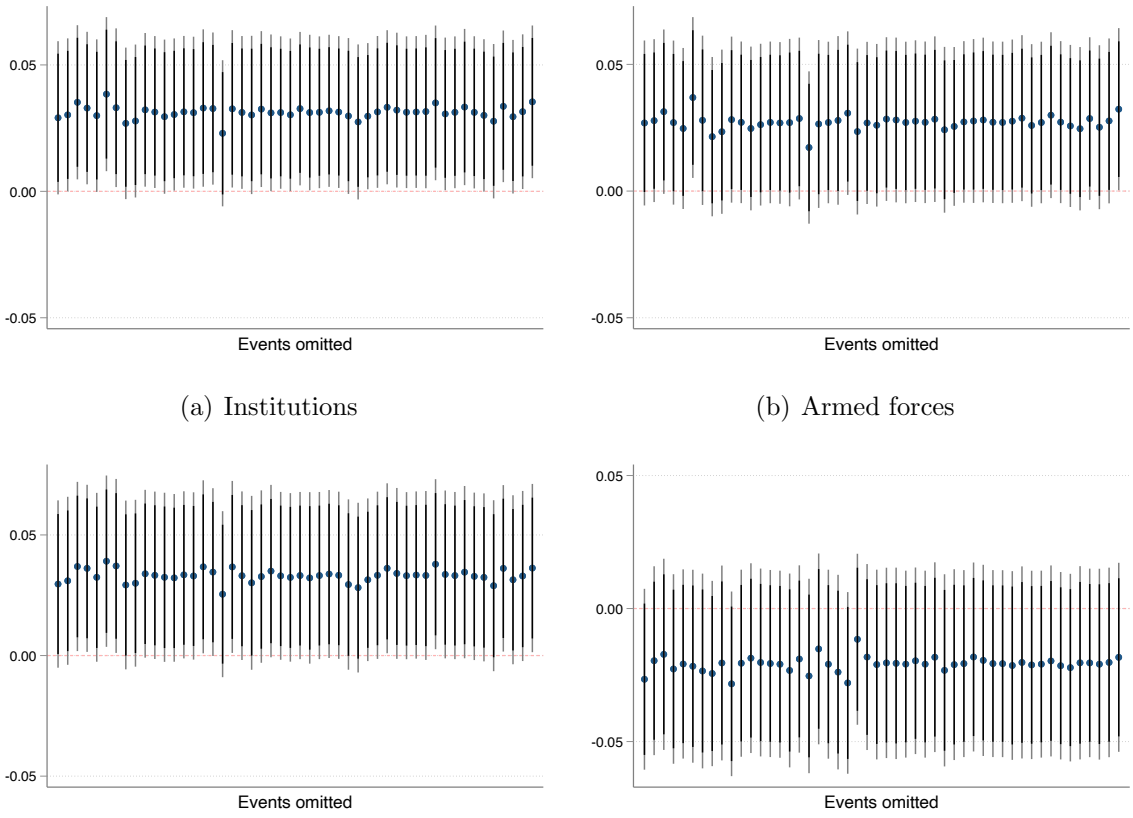
(b) Armed forces

(c) Government

(d) Interpersonal

Notes: The figure reports robustness of the estimated treatment effects to the exclusion of individual high-profile civilian deaths caused by police officers. Each point shows the estimated coefficient from the baseline specification in Table 2, Panel A, obtained after excluding one event at a time from the estimation sample. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level. Vertical lines represent 90% and 95% confidence intervals. The results show that the estimated effects are not driven by any single event.

Figure A10: Robustness to exclusion of individual events – Police-officer-death events



(a) Institutions

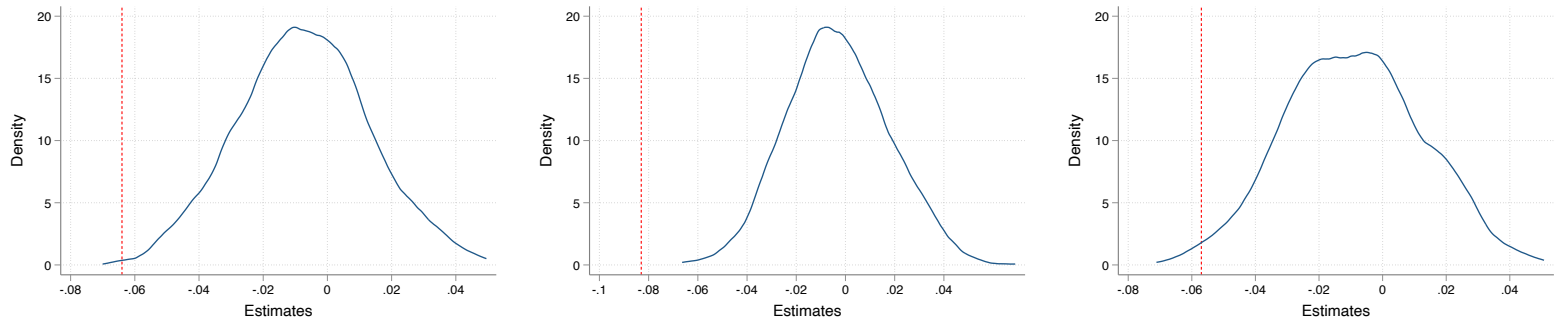
(b) Armed forces

(c) Government

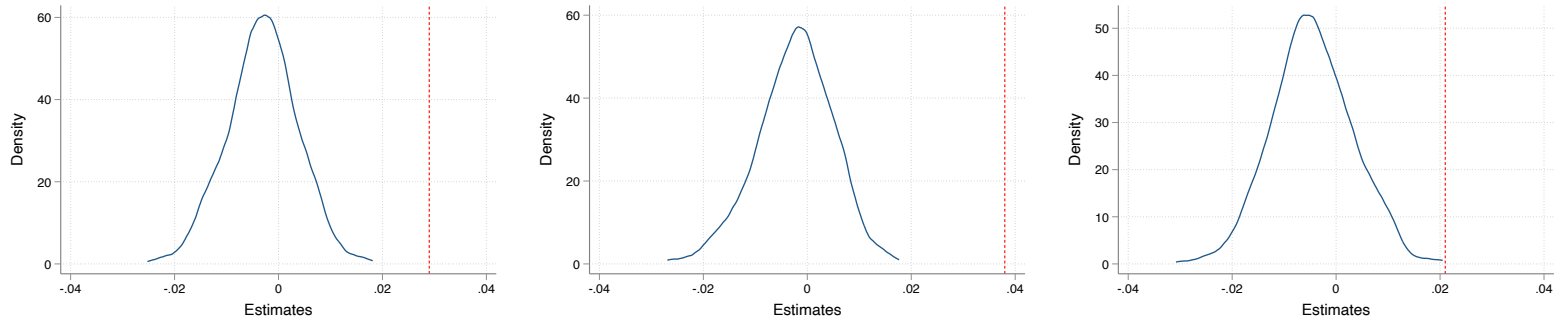
(d) Interpersonal

Notes: The figure reports robustness of the estimated treatment effects to the exclusion of individual high-profile police-officer deaths caused by civilians. Each point shows the estimated coefficient from the baseline specification in Table 2, Panel B, obtained after excluding one event at a time from the estimation sample. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level.Vertical lines represent 90% and 95% confidence intervals. The results show that the estimated effects are not driven by any single event.

Figure A11: Placebo test using surveys without fatalities – Civilian-death events



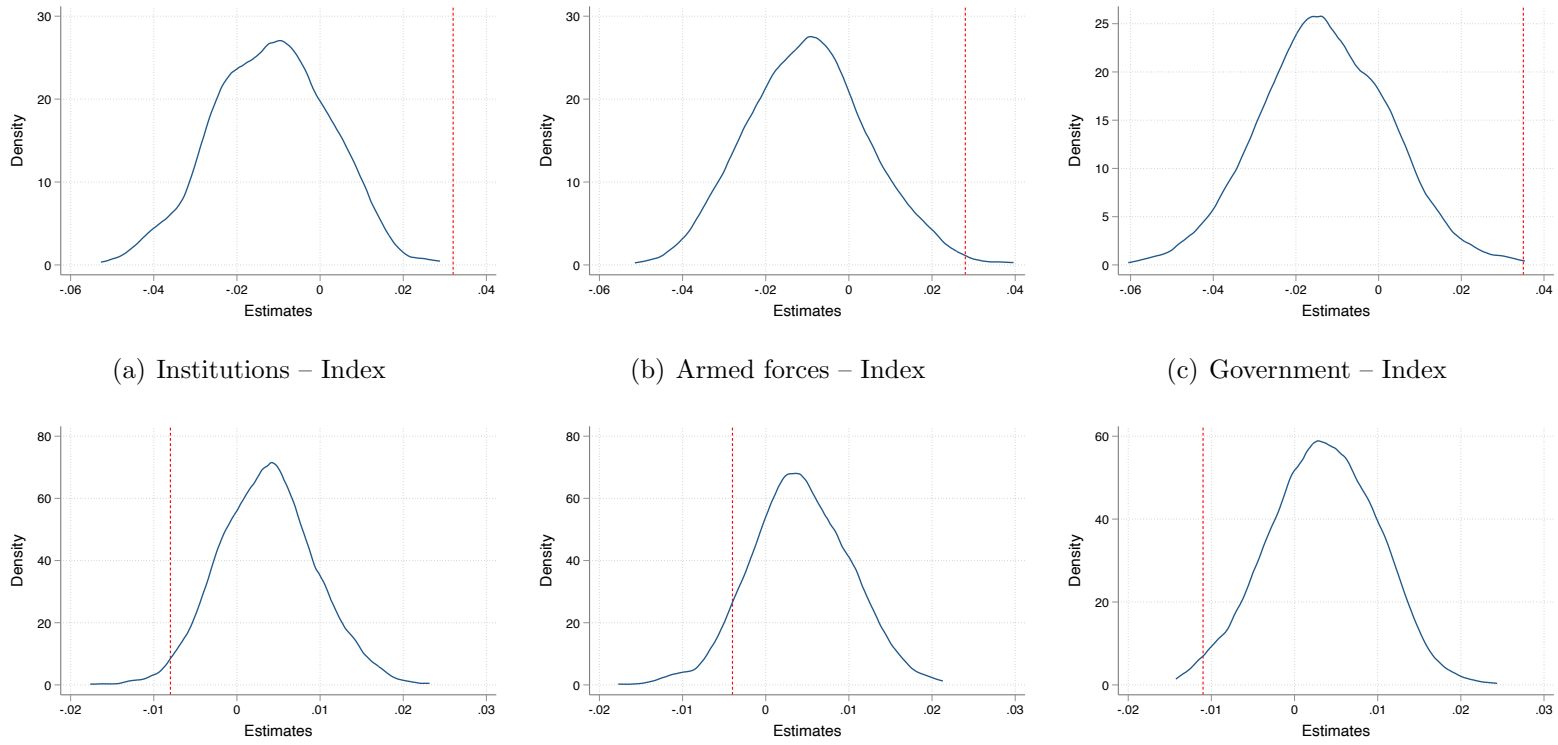
(a) Institutions – Index (b) Armed forces – Index (c) Government – Index



(d) Institutions – No trust (e) Armed forces – No trust (f) Government – No trust

Notes: The figure reports placebo tests based on surveys in which no high-profile civilian death occurred. For each iteration, we randomly select 20 surveys without fatalities and randomly assign a placebo event date within the survey period. We then estimate the baseline specification used in Table 2, Panel A. The plots show the distribution of the resulting placebo estimates across simulations. The vertical red line indicates the corresponding estimate from the main specification. Reported p-values correspond to randomization inference tests comparing the observed estimate with the simulated distribution: Panel A ($p = 0.001$), Panel B ($p < 0.001$), Panel C ($p = 0.01$), Panel D ($p < 0.001$), Panel E ($p < 0.001$), and Panel F ($p < 0.001$).

Figure A12: Placebo test using surveys without fatalities – Police-officer-death events



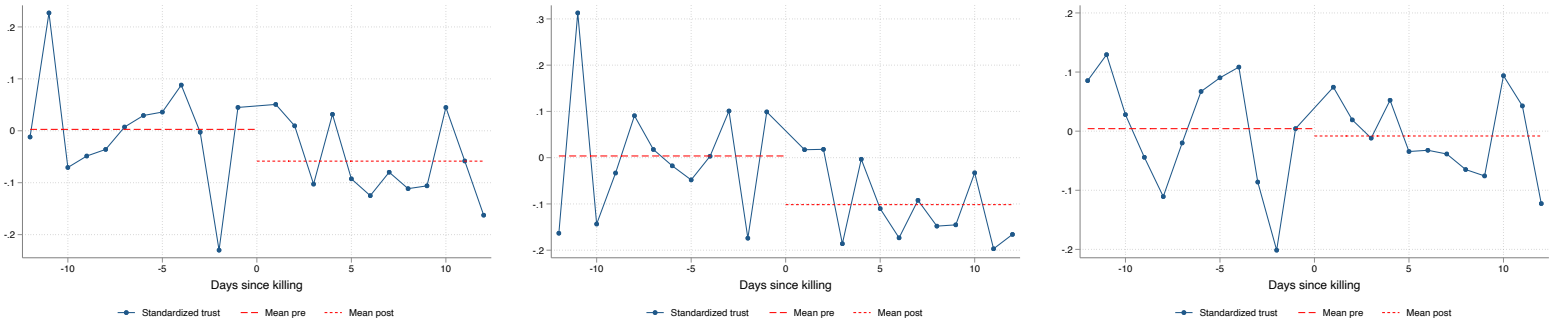
(a) Institutions – Index (b) Armed forces – Index (c) Government – Index

(d) Institutions – No trust (e) Armed forces – No trust (f) Government – No trust

Notes: The figure reports placebo tests based on surveys in which no high-profile police-officer death occurred. For each iteration, we randomly select 65 surveys without fatalities and randomly assign a placebo event date within the survey period. We then estimate the baseline specification used in Table 2, Panel B. The plots show the distribution of the resulting placebo estimates across simulations. The vertical red line indicates the corresponding estimate from the main specification. Reported p-values correspond to randomization inference tests comparing the observed estimate with the simulated distribution: Panel A ($p < 0.001$), Panel B ($p = 0.005$), Panel C ($p = 0.001$), Panel D ($p = 0.018$), Panel E ($p = 0.080$), and Panel F ($p = 0.014$).

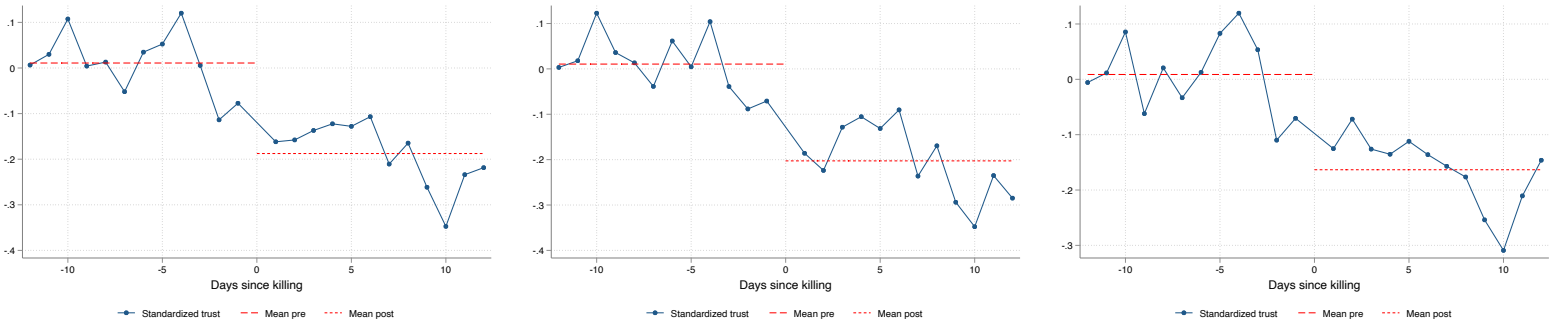
Figure A13: Dynamics of trust around civilian-death events by protest activity

Events occurring during weeks with protest activity



(a) State institutions (b) Armed forces (c) Government

Events occurring during weeks without protest activity



(d) State institutions (e) Armed forces (f) Government

Notes: The figure presents the evolution of trust around civilian-death events separately by protest activity. Panels (a)–(c) correspond to events occurring during weeks with protest activity, while panels (d)–(f) correspond to events occurring during weeks without protest activity. Trust is standardized using the pre-event mean and standard deviation within the corresponding survey. Points report mean standardized trust by interview day relative to the event; horizontal lines report average trust before and after the event.

Table A1: Semantic characteristics of newspaper headlines

	Police-officer is involved		
	Civilian-death events	Police-officer-death events	Comparison with civilian only GDELT
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Active voice without subject	0.17	0.35	0.20
Active voice with subject	0.46	0.35	0.34
Non-verbal voice	0.28	0.16	0.30
Passive voice	0.09	0.14	0.16
Focus: Victim	0.63	0.27	0.98
Focus: Perpetrator	0.35	0.73	0.01
State is mentioned	0.37	0.79	0.02
Number of words	11.05	10.54	10.53
Headlines	681	2,305	158

Notes: The table reports descriptive statistics for semantic characteristics of newspaper headlines describing police–civilian fatalities. Column (1) corresponds to incidents in which police officers kill civilians, and column (2) to incidents in which civilians kill police officers. Column (3) reports a comparison sample of headlines referring to civilian killings drawn from the GDELT database. The first four rows classify headlines according to grammatical structure. "Active voice without subject" refers to headlines where the verb appears without an explicit subject (e.g., "Kill police officer in attack"), while "active voice with subject" includes headlines where the perpetrator is explicitly stated. "Non-verbal voice" refers to headlines without a verb, and "passive voice" includes constructions where the victim is the grammatical subject. The rows labeled "Focus: Victim" and "Focus: Perpetrator" identify whether the headline emphasizes the victim or the perpetrator. "State is mentioned" indicates whether the state or its security forces are explicitly referenced (e.g. "Police brutality in Flores" or "Police officer who shot and killed young man has been identified"; own translation and underlined). "Number of words" reports the average headline length. All headlines were originally written in Spanish or Portuguese. Semantic classification was conducted separately for each language.

Table A2: Balance in headline semantics around survey fieldwork

	All		Outside survey		Within survey		Pairwise t-test	
	N	Mean	N	Mean	N	Mean	N	Difference
Panel A: Civilian-death events		(1)		(2)		(3)		(4)
Active voice without subject	681	0.167	611	0.164	70	0.200	681	0.036
		(0.374)		(0.370)		(0.403)		
Active voice with subject	681	0.455	611	0.465	70	0.371	681	-0.093
		(0.498)		(0.499)		(0.487)		
Non-verbal voice	681	0.283	611	0.275	70	0.357	681	0.082
		(0.451)		(0.447)		(0.483)		
Passive voice	681	0.094	611	0.097	70	0.071	681	-0.025
		(0.292)		(0.296)		(0.259)		
Focus: Victim	681	0.631	611	0.620	70	0.729	681	0.108*
		(0.483)		(0.486)		(0.448)		
Focus: Perpetrator	681	0.348	611	0.360	70	0.243	681	-0.117*
		(0.477)		(0.480)		(0.432)		
State is mentioned	681	0.373	611	0.386	70	0.257	681	-0.129**
		(0.484)		(0.487)		(0.440)		
Number of words	681	11.051	611	11.137	70	10.300	681	-0.837*
		(4.029)		(4.096)		(3.316)		
Panel B: Police-officer-death events								
Active voice without subject	2305	0.347	2079	0.348	226	0.336	2305	-0.011
		(0.476)		(0.476)		(0.473)		
Active voice with subject	2305	0.355	2079	0.357	226	0.332	2305	-0.026
		(0.479)		(0.479)		(0.472)		
Non-verbal voice	2305	0.160	2079	0.157	226	0.186	2305	0.029
		(0.366)		(0.364)		(0.390)		
Passive voice	2305	0.139	2079	0.138	226	0.146	2305	0.008
		(0.346)		(0.345)		(0.354)		
Focus: Victim	2305	0.272	2079	0.271	226	0.274	2305	0.003
		(0.445)		(0.445)		(0.447)		
Focus: Perpetrator	2305	0.727	2079	0.727	226	0.726	2305	-0.001
		(0.446)		(0.446)		(0.447)		
State is mentioned	2305	0.791	2079	0.790	226	0.801	2305	0.011
		(0.406)		(0.407)		(0.400)		
Number of words	2305	10.537	2079	10.556	226	10.358	2305	-0.198
		(3.320)		(3.342)		(3.107)		

Notes: The table reports descriptive statistics for semantic characteristics of newspaper headlines covering police–civilian fatalities. Panel A refers to incidents in which police officers kill civilians, and Panel B to incidents in which civilians kill police officers. Columns (1)–(3) report the number of headlines and mean values for all events, events outside survey fieldwork, and events occurring during survey fieldwork. Column (4) reports the difference in means between headlines covering events within and outside survey periods. Standard deviations are reported in parentheses. Statistical significance: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A3: Balance of events in estimation sample selection

		Within survey		Difference	
	Outside survey	Estimating sample	Not in estimating sample	(2) - (1)	(2) - (3)
Panel A: Civilian-death events	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Number of deaths	3.391	3.550	5.500	0.159	-1.950
	(7.619)	(8.959)	(6.364)	[0.931]	[0.769]
During protest	0.356	0.550	1.000	0.194	-0.450
	(0.480)	(0.510)	(0.000)	[0.091]	[0.237]
Organized crime involved	0.075	0.050	0.000	-0.025	0.050
	(0.264)	(0.224)	(0.000)	[0.688]	[0.760]
Police officer on duty	0.839	0.850	1.000	0.011	-0.150
	(0.369)	(0.366)	(0.000)	[0.900]	[0.577]
Media coverage	3.511	3.200	3.000	-0.311	0.200
	(1.316)	(1.473)	(2.828)	[0.323]	[0.865]
Observations	174	20	2	194	22
Panel B: Police-officer-death events					
Number of deaths	1.507	1.323	1.444	-0.184	-0.121
	(1.703)	(0.773)	(1.319)	[0.388]	[0.561]
During protest	0.009	0.031	0.083	0.021	-0.053
	(0.096)	(0.174)	(0.280)	[0.102]	[0.248]
Organized crime involved	0.598	0.585	0.694	-0.013	-0.110
	(0.491)	(0.497)	(0.467)	[0.837]	[0.280]
Police officer on duty	0.719	0.692	0.750	-0.027	-0.058
	(0.450)	(0.465)	(0.439)	[0.640]	[0.544]
Media coverage	2.178	2.308	2.667	0.130	-0.359
	(1.215)	(1.224)	(1.242)	[0.403]	[0.163]
Observations	969	65	36	1034	101

Notes: Summary statistics for high-profile civilian-death and police-officer-death events. Column (1) reports events occurring outside survey fieldwork. Columns (2) and (3) report events occurring during survey fieldwork that are included in the estimating sample and those excluded, respectively. Columns (4) and (5) report differences in means, with p-values in brackets. For civilian-death events, 22 events occur during survey fieldwork, of which 18 are used for estimation and 4 are excluded. For police-officer-death events, 97 events occur during survey fieldwork, of which 55 are used for estimation and 42 are excluded. Events are excluded when they overlap with an earlier event within the same survey or do not generate sufficient usable observations around the event within the $\pm$12-day window.

Table A4: Indicator for no trust

Dependent variable: Indicator for no trust in ...				
	State institutions	Armed forces	Government	Interpersonal
Panel A. Civilian-death events	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
After *civilian-death* event	0.029***	0.038***	0.021*	0.000
	(0.009)	(0.009)	(0.011)	(0.012)
Panel B. Police-officer-death events				
After *police-officer-death* event	-0.008	-0.004	-0.011	0.003
	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.007)	(0.007)
Observations (panel A)	13,593	13,593	12,961	13,329
Observations (panel B)	37,085	37,085	36,199	36,292
Avg. dependent variable (panel A)	0.238	0.193	0.278	0.588
Avg. dependent variable (panel B)	0.254	0.202	0.302	0.508
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1). The variable *After civilian-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which police officers killed one or more civilians, and zero otherwise. The variable *After police-officer-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which civilians killed one or more police officers, and zero otherwise. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding event. The dependent variable equals one if the respondent reports the lowest possible level of trust in the corresponding outcome. All specifications include country-by-survey fixed effects and the following individual controls: gender, age, two education indicators, and computer ownership. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A5: Alternative measures of institutional trust

Dependent variable: Institutional trust index			
	PCA	Polychoric PCA	Factor
Panel A. Civilian-death events	(1)	(2)	(3)
After *civilian death* event	-0.140***	-0.044***	-0.072***
	(0.048)	(0.015)	(0.026)
Panel B. Police-officer-death events			
After *police-officer death* event	0.065*	0.019*	0.036**
	(0.034)	(0.010)	(0.018)
Observations (panel A)	12,657	12,657	12,657
Observations (panel B)	35,672	35,672	35,672
Avg. dependent variable (panel A)	0.194	0.913	0.103
Avg. dependent variable (panel B)	0.113	0.837	0.0654
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1) using alternative aggregations of the institutional-trust measures. Column (1) uses the first principal component from a principal component analysis of the standardized trust variables. Column (2) uses a polychoric principal component analysis, replacing the Pearson correlation matrix with a polychoric correlation matrix. Column (3) uses the predicted score from a one-factor maximum-likelihood factor model. The variable *After civilian-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which police officers killed one or more civilians, and zero otherwise. The variable *After police-officer-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which civilians killed one or more police officers, and zero otherwise. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding event. All specifications include country-by-survey fixed effects and the following individual controls: gender, age, two education indicators, and computer ownership. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A6: Effects on satisfaction with democracy and political ideology

	Satisfaction with democracy	Political ideology
Panel A. Civilian-death events	(1)	(2)
After *civilian-death* event	0.008	-0.009
	(0.008)	(0.007)
Panel B. Police-officer-death events		
After *police-officer-death* event	0.006	0.013***
	(0.005)	(0.005)
Observations (panel A)	12,313	10,593
Observations (panel B)	34,784	29,350
R-squared (panel A)	0.154	0.036
R-squared (panel B)	0.173	0.041
Avg. dependent variable (panel A)	0.465	0.503
Avg. dependent variable (panel B)	0.447	0.507
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1). Column (1) uses satisfaction with democracy as the dependent variable, while column (2) uses respondents' political ideology, with higher values indicating positions further to the right. The variable *After civilian-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which police officers killed one or more civilians, and zero otherwise. The variable *After police-officer-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which civilians killed one or more police officers, and zero otherwise. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding event. All specifications include country-by-survey fixed effects and the following individual controls: gender, age, two education indicators, and computer ownership. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A7: High ratios of police-officer-death to civilian-death events

	Standardized trust in ...		
	State institutions	Armed forces	Government
	(1)	(2)	(3)
After *police-officer death* event	0.040**	0.053**	0.028
	(0.020)	(0.021)	(0.023)
Observations	18,788	18,788	18,668
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1). The variable *After police-officer-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a police officer was killed by civilians. We exclude from the estimating sample the 3 countries with the largest ratio of police-officer to civilian death events (Argentina, Colombia, and Mexico). The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding fatality. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. The standardized trust variables have mean zero and standard deviation one. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A8: Alternative clustering method

Dependent variable: Standardized trust in ...			
	State institutions	Armed forces	Government
Panel A. Civilian-death events	(1)	(2)	(3)
After *civilian-death* event	-0.064**	-0.083*	-0.057**
p-value wild bootstrap	0.015	0.056	0.042
Panel B. Police-officer-death events			
After *police-officer-death* event	0.032*	0.028	0.035*
p-value wild bootstrap	0.066	0.143	0.057
Observations (panel A)	13,593	13,593	12,961
Observations (panel B)	37,085	37,085	36,199
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1). The variable *After civilian-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which police officers killed one or more civilians, and zero otherwise. The variable *After police-officer-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which civilians killed one or more police officers, and zero otherwise. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding event. All trust measures are standardized to have mean zero and standard deviation one. All specifications include country-by-survey fixed effects and the following individual controls: gender, age, two education indicators, and computer ownership. The row below each coefficient reports *p*-values from a wild cluster bootstrap at the survey-country level following Cameron et al. (2008). Significance stars are based on these wild-bootstrap *p*-values: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A9: Baseline results using survey sampling weights

Dependent variable:	Standardized measure of trust in...				Indicator for no trust in...			
	State institutions	Armed forces	Government	Interpersonal	State institutions	Armed forces	Government	Interpersonal
Panel A. Civilian-death events	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
After *civilian death* event	-0.051**	-0.069**	-0.047*	-0.008	0.023**	0.035***	0.018	0.008
	(0.022)	(0.028)	(0.027)	(0.031)	(0.009)	(0.010)	(0.012)	(0.012)
Panel B. Police-officer-death events								
After *police-officer-death* event	0.032**	0.025	0.038**	-0.017	-0.006	-0.003	-0.009	0.001
	(0.015)	(0.017)	(0.017)	(0.019)	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.007)	(0.007)
Observations (panel A)	12,494	12,399	11,866	12,243	12,494	12,419	11,905	12,429
Observations (panel B)	34,941	34,408	34,065	34,189	34,941	34,459	34,165	34,619
Avg. dependent variable (panel A)	0	0	0	0	0.240	0.194	0.278	0.578
Avg. dependent variable (panel B)	0	0	0	0	0.260	0.205	0.310	0.526
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1) using survey sampling weights provided by Latinobarómetro and LAPOP. The variable *After civilian-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile civilian death caused by police officers, and zero otherwise. The variable *After police-officer-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a police officer was killed by civilians. Panel A reports results for civilian deaths and Panel B for police-officer deaths. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding fatality. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A10: Randomization inference

Dependent variable: Standardized trust in ...			
	State institutions	Armed forces	Government
Panel A. Civilian-death events	(1)	(2)	(3)
After *civilian-death* event	-0.043***	-0.057***	-0.038***
Randomization p-value	<0.01	<0.01	<0.01
Panel B. Police-officer-death events			
After *police-officer-death* event	0.021***	0.019**	0.024***
Randomization p-value	<0.01	0.022	<0.01
Observations (panel A)	13,699	13,598	13,062
Observations (panel B)	37,085	37,085	36,199
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1). The row below each coefficient reports p-values obtained using randomization inference following Cattaneo et al. (2015), and using their Stata package `rdrandinf` and uniform weights. The dependent variable is the outcome residualized on country-by-survey fixed effects and individual controls: gender, age, two education indicators, and computer ownership. The variable *After civilian-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which police officers killed one or more civilians, and zero otherwise. The variable *After police-officer-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which civilians killed one or more police officers, and zero otherwise. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding event. Significance stars are based on the randomization-inference p-values: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A11: Missing survey responses

	Response missing				At least one missing		
	Institutions	Armed forces	Government	Interpersonal	Institutions	Armed forces	Government
Panel A. Civilian-death events	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
After *civilian-death* event	0.004	-0.001	0.001	-0.009**	-0.003	-0.004	0.002
	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.004)	(0.005)	(0.004)	(0.004)
Panel B. Police-officer-death events							
After *police-officer-death* event	0.001	0.002	-0.000	0.002	0.008*	0.004	0.006
	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.003)	(0.004)	(0.002)	(0.004)
Observations (panel A)	14,394	14,394	14,394	14,394	14,394	14,394	14,394
Observations (panel B)	39,839	39,839	39,839	39,839	39,839	39,839	39,839
Avg. dependent variable (panel A)	0.0591	0.0669	0.121	0.0234	0.462	0.176	0.445
Avg. dependent variable (panel B)	0.0432	0.0492	0.0624	0.0234	0.486	0.0834	0.478
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1) using indicators for missing responses to the corresponding trust variables as dependent variables. Columns (1)–(4) equal one if the response to the indicated trust question is missing. Columns (5)–(7) equal one if at least one of the corresponding trust variables is missing. Panel A reports results for civilian deaths caused by police officers and Panel B for police-officer deaths caused by civilians. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. Statistical significance: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A12: Placebo events based on previous survey waves

	Dependent variable: Standardized trust in ...		
	State institutions	Armed forces	Government
Panel A. Civilian-death events	(1)	(2)	(3)
After placebo *civilian-death* event	0.002	-0.012	0.007
	(0.023)	(0.029)	(0.024)
Panel B. Police-officer-death events			
After placebo *police-officer-death* event	0.004	0.015	-0.005
	(0.015)	(0.017)	(0.016)
Observations (panel A)	15,684	15,610	15,591
Observations (panel B)	40,711	40,630	39,796
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1) using placebo events based on previous survey waves. Panel A reports results for civilian-death events and Panel B for police-officer-death events. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding placebo event. All specifications include country-by-survey fixed effects aand the following individual controls: gender, age, two education indicators, and computer ownership. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A13: Robustness to protest activity

Sample:	No protest in previous week			Event occurs during protest		
	Dep. variable: Standardized trust in ...					
	State institutions	Armed forces	Government	State institutions	Armed forces	Government
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
After *civilian death* event	-0.077**	-0.096***	-0.077**	-0.074**	-0.093***	-0.065
	(0.030)	(0.032)	(0.038)	(0.030)	(0.031)	(0.040)
Observations	8,825	8,825	8,229	5,984	5,984	5,825
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1). Columns (1)–(3) restrict the sample to cases with no protest in the previous week, while columns (4)–(6) restrict the sample to civilian-death events occurring during a protest. The variable *After civilian-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile civilian death caused by police officers and zero otherwise. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding fatality. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. The standardized trust variables have mean zero and standard deviation one. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A14: Heterogeneous effects by context characteristics

	Dependent variable: Standardized trust in ...					
	Armed forces			Government		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Panel A. Civilian-death events						
After *civilian death* event	-0.083***	-0.084***	-0.083***	-0.056**	-0.058**	-0.062**
	(0.027)	(0.028)	(0.029)	(0.026)	(0.027)	(0.026)
× Quality of democracy	-0.004			-0.012		
	(0.024)			(0.017)		
× Recent killings		0.027*			-0.002	
		(0.015)			(0.031)	
× Baseline trust			-0.002			-0.031**
			(0.025)			(0.015)
Panel B. Police-officer-death events						
After *police-officer death* event	0.028*	0.028*	0.028*	0.035**	0.036**	0.035**
	(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.018)
× Quality of democracy	0.001			0.004		
	(0.011)			(0.015)		
× Recent killings		0.000			0.001	
		(0.001)			(0.001)	
× Baseline trust			-0.002			-0.021
			(0.014)			(0.021)
Observations (panel A)	13,593	13,593	13,593	12,961	12,961	12,961
Observations (panel B)	37,085	37,085	37,085	36,199	36,199	36,199
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1), allowing the effect of high-profile events to vary with country and local characteristics. The variable *After civilian-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which police officers killed one or more civilians, and zero otherwise. The variable *After police-officer-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which civilians killed one or more police officers, and zero otherwise. Interaction terms allow the treatment effect to vary with (i) the quality of democracy (standardized), (ii) recent killings, and (iii) baseline trust in the corresponding institution. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding event. All specifications include country-by-survey fixed effects and the following individual controls: gender, age, two education indicators, and computer ownership. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A15: Additional heterogeneity in the effects on trust

	Dependent variable: Standardized trust in ...					
	Armed forces			Government		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Panel A. Civilian-death events						
After *civilian death* event	-0.082***	-0.098***	-0.111***	-0.053**	-0.068**	-0.093***
	(0.027)	(0.031)	(0.030)	(0.025)	(0.026)	(0.031)
× Years of dictatorship	0.001			0.003		
	(0.002)			(0.002)		
× Right-wing ideology		-0.311**			-0.217*	
		(0.152)			(0.127)	
× Distance to event			0.040			0.007
			(0.025)			(0.024)
Panel B. Police-officer-death events						
After *police-officer* death	0.027*	0.023	0.027*	0.035*	0.035*	0.038**
	(0.016)	(0.017)	(0.016)	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.017)
× Years of dictatorship	-0.000			-0.001		
	(0.001)			(0.001)		
× Right-wing		-0.067			-0.115**	
		(0.051)			(0.056)	
× Distance to event			0.027**			0.030**
			(0.012)			(0.014)
Observations (panel A)	13,593	10,593	8,363	12,961	10,559	7,881
Observations (panel B)	37,085	29,350	35,907	36,199	29,197	35,042
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1), allowing the effect of high-profile events to vary with additional respondent and context characteristics. The variable *After civilian-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which police officers killed one or more civilians, and zero otherwise. The variable *After police-officer-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which civilians killed one or more police officers, and zero otherwise. The interaction terms capture heterogeneity with respect to (i) years under dictatorship, demeaned; (ii) political ideology, with higher values indicating more right-wing positions, demeaned; and (iii) distance in kilometers between the municipality of the event and the respondent's municipality, standardized. Columns (3) and (6) additionally control for distance to the event. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding event. All specifications include country-by-survey fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A16: Heterogeneity by event characteristics – Civilian-death events

	Dependent variable: Standardized trust in ...											
	Armed forces						Government					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)	(11)	(12)
After *civilian death* event	-0.078***	-0.075*	-0.087***	-0.086***	-0.079***	-0.081***	-0.055**	-0.063*	-0.048**	-0.049**	-0.055**	-0.052**
	(0.025)	(0.043)	(0.025)	(0.025)	(0.028)	(0.027)	(0.026)	(0.035)	(0.022)	(0.023)	(0.025)	(0.024)
× Number of outlets	-0.050***						-0.019					
	(0.016)						(0.017)					
× During crime		-0.006						0.045				
		(0.057)						(0.054)				
× Headline: State mentioned			-0.032						0.078			
			(0.067)						(0.054)			
× Headline: Perpetrator				-0.031						0.077		
				(0.067)						(0.054)		
× Headline: Active voice					0.122						0.047	
					(0.080)						(0.076)	
× Headline: Blame state						0.042						0.091
						(0.064)						(0.055)
Observations	13,593	13,593	13,593	13,593	13,593	13,593	12,961	12,961	12,961	12,961	12,961	12,961
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1), allowing the effect of civilian-death events to vary with characteristics of the event and its media coverage. The variable *After civilian-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which police officers killed one or more civilians, and zero otherwise. Interaction terms capture heterogeneity with respect to the number of major media outlets reporting the event, whether the event occurs during a crime, and several semantic characteristics of the headlines describing the event. Headline characteristics indicate whether the state is mentioned, whether the perpetrator is emphasized, whether the headline uses active voice, and whether the wording assigns blame to the state. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding event. All specifications include country-by-survey fixed effects and the following individual controls: gender, age, two education indicators, and computer ownership. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A17: Heterogeneity by event characteristics – Police-officer-death events

	Dependent variable: Standardized trust in ...											
	Armed forces						Government					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)	(11)	(12)
After *police-officer death* event	0.028*	0.029*	0.050	0.048	0.022	0.028	0.035**	0.038**	0.009	0.061	0.028	0.034
	(0.016)	(0.017)	(0.064)	(0.042)	(0.023)	(0.022)	(0.018)	(0.019)	(0.080)	(0.050)	(0.024)	(0.023)
× # of outlets	-0.006						0.002					
	(0.012)						(0.014)					
× During crime		-0.013						-0.032				
		(0.045)						(0.050)				
× Headline: State mentioned			-0.025						0.031			
			(0.071)						(0.086)			
× Headline: Perpetrator				-0.025						-0.033		
				(0.051)						(0.058)		
× Headline: Active voice					0.025						0.028	
					(0.043)						(0.049)	
× Headline: Blame state						0.004						0.011
						(0.053)						(0.057)
Observations	37,085	37,085	35,945	35,945	35,945	35,945	36,199	36,199	35,059	35,059	35,059	35,059
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1), allowing the effect of police-officer-death events to vary with characteristics of the event and its media coverage. The variable *After police-officer-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which civilians killed one or more police officers, and zero otherwise. Interaction terms capture heterogeneity with respect to the number of major media outlets reporting the event, whether the event occurs during a crime, and several semantic characteristics of the headlines describing the event. Headline characteristics indicate whether the state is mentioned, whether the perpetrator is emphasized, whether the headline uses active voice, and whether the wording assigns blame to the state. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding event. All specifications include country-by-survey fixed effects and individual controls. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A18: Balance of civilian-death events by timing of media coverage

Civilian-death events	All	Early coverage	Delayed coverage	Difference (3)–(2)
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Number of deaths	3.550	1.785	7.667	5.881
	(8.959)	(1.888)	(16.330)	[0.190]
Occurred during protest	0.550	0.714	0.167	-0.547
	(0.510)	(0.468)	(0.408)	[0.023]
Organized crime was involved	0.050	0.071	0.000	-0.071
	(0.223)	(0.267)	(0.000)	[0.527]
Police officer was on duty	0.850	0.857	0.833	-0.023
	(0.366)	(0.363)	(0.408)	[0.892]
Number of media outlets covering event	3.200	3.571	2.333	-1.238
	(1.472)	(1.222)	(1.715)	[0.085]
State mentioned in headlines	0.404	0.413	0.387	-0.026
	(0.368)	(0.361)	(0.386)	[0.646]
Perpetrator focus in headlines	0.380	0.382	0.375	-0.007
	(0.368)	(0.362)	(0.383)	[0.899]
Observations	20	14	6	20

Notes: Summary statistics for civilian-death events in the estimating sample. Early media coverage refers to events covered by major national media within 12 days of the event, while delayed media coverage refers to events not covered within 12 days. Columns (1)–(3) report means with standard deviations in parentheses for all events, events with early media coverage, and events with delayed media coverage, respectively. Column (4) reports differences in means (delayed minus early), with p-values in brackets. Media coverage measures the number of major national newspaper outlets reporting the event. The bottom two headline variables are computed as the share of articles covering the event that mention the state or focus on the perpetrator.

Table A19: Police-officer-death events with early media coverage

Dependent variable: Standardized trust in ...			
	State institutions	Armed forces	Government
	(1)	(2)	(3)
After *police-officer death* event	0.031*	0.023	0.038**
	(0.016)	(0.017)	(0.019)
Observations	33,444	33,444	32,591
Country-by-survey fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each observation is a survey respondent and each column reports estimates of equation (1). The sample is restricted to police-officer-death events with early media coverage, defined as events covered by major national media within 12 days of the event. The variable *After police-officer-death event* equals one if the respondent was interviewed after a high-profile event in which civilians killed one or more police officers, and zero otherwise. Due to data limitations, there is insufficient variation to estimate local effects for these events. The sample includes respondents interviewed within ±12 days of the corresponding event. All specifications include country-by-survey fixed effects and the following individual controls: gender, age, two education indicators, and computer ownership. Standard errors are clustered at the survey-country-region level and reported in parentheses. Significance levels: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.